



To subscribe,
give a missed call at
9828331787
or scan QR code



Chennai » Coimbatore » Bengaluru » Hyderabad » Madurai » Noida » Visakhapatnam » Thiruvananthapuram » Kochi » Vijayawada » Mangaluru » Tiruchirappalli » Kolkata » Hubballi » Mohali » Malappuram » Mumbai » Lucknow » Cuttack » Patna



EXTENDED RELAXATION
Ease Class 6 language policy, SC directs CBSE
NEWS » PAGE 4



UPI CHARGES
SC questions government's power to levy merchant fees
NEWS » PAGE 4



'UNFULFILLED PROMISE'
J&K Assembly passes Statehood resolution
NEWS » PAGE 4

CONFLICT ZONE
Time runs short for Iran and America
Both must hear the bells toll as economies falter
EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



WAR AND PERSECUTION
Pope urges Europeans to welcome migrants
WORLD » PAGE 14

NEARBY



U.S. will be forced to leave West Asia region: Mojtaba

TEHRAN
Iran's Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei said on Monday that the United States would be forced to leave West Asia after suffering "painful blows". Mr. Khamenei made the remarks despite attempts by Qatari mediators to revive talks aimed at ending the fight. » PAGE 14

Major oil spill off Odisha averted by Coast Guard

BHUBANESWAR
The Indian Coast Guard rescued a distressed foreign vessel, *MT Seagull 9*, off the Odisha coast on Sunday and prevented a major oil spill. The Belize-flagged vessel carrying 9,000 tonnes of palm oil issued a distress call after its main engine failed and ballast tank started flooding. » PAGE 4

'Bullet train work not up to Japan's expectations'

TOKYO
The rate of progress on the Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed rail corridor project has not "lived up to" Japan's initial expectations, a senior official of Japan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs said on Monday. Japan supports India's first bullet train project, financially and technically. » PAGE 4

U.S., China issue product lists for tariff reduction

HONG KONG
The United States and China released on Monday reciprocal lists of products worth about \$30 billion each that will see tariff cuts in a deal expected to boost bilateral trade. The details emerge days after Chinese President Xi Jinping met President Donald Trump in Washington. » PAGE 14

Authorities lax on women's safety in Delhi: SC

SC takes *suo motu* cognisance of recent cases of sexual violence reported from the Delhi-NCR area

'Preventable issues' should not make women unsafe in parks, and public transport, it says

The right to live with dignity, free from the fear of violence, is enshrined in Article 21 the bench said

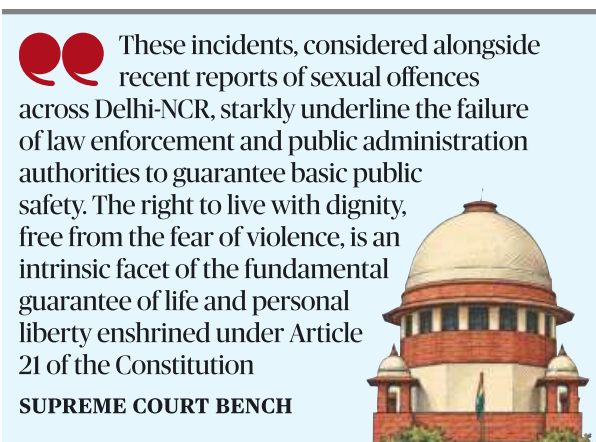
Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Taking *suo motu* cognisance of a spate of sexual assault incidents against minors and women in the Delhi-National Capital Region (NCR), the Supreme Court on Monday directed the Delhi Police to immediately identify vulnerable pockets, step up patrolling, and undertake an audit of lighting and CCTV coverage in public spaces within four weeks.

A Bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and K. Vinod Chandran observed that public spaces, including parks, buses, and Metro stations, cannot be allowed to become "zones of high risk" because of deficiencies such as "grossly inadequate illumination" and "lax patrolling". Where basic measures of public safety remain compromised, no individual,

irrespective of age, gender or sexual identity, can navigate public spaces with a sense of security, it said.

It took note of several recent cases of sexual violence reported in the national capital, including the rape of a 17-year-old at Astha Kunj park near Lady Shri Ram College, the gang-rape of a minor at Swaroop Nagar, and the sexual assault of another minor inside a bus travelling from Greater Noida to Delhi. "These incidents, considered alongside recent reports of sexual offences across Delhi-NCR, starkly underline the failure of law enforcement and public administration authorities to guarantee basic public safety. The right to live with dignity, free from the fear of violence, is an intrinsic facet of the fundamental guarantee of life and personal liberty enshrined under Article 21 of the Constitu-



These incidents, considered alongside recent reports of sexual offences across Delhi-NCR, starkly underline the failure of law enforcement and public administration authorities to guarantee basic public safety. The right to live with dignity, free from the fear of violence, is an intrinsic facet of the fundamental guarantee of life and personal liberty enshrined under Article 21 of the Constitution

SUPREME COURT BENCH

tion," the Bench said.

The Delhi Police and other authorities have also been asked to file a detailed response outlining the measures currently in place to ensure safety at areas frequented by women and children.

Nirbhaya case

Expressing serious concern over the gang-rape of a 17-year-old girl in a moving bus that travelled near-

ly 47 km from Greater Noida to Kashmere Gate without being stopped at a single police picket earlier this month, the apex court said it could not help but "draw painful parallels with the 2012 Nirbhaya case". The incident, it said, raised questions over whether systemic law-enforcement mechanisms had made any "meaningful progress" in the years since then.

Flying high



Great effort: Sreeshankar leapt to a long jump silver medal at the Asian Games on Monday. India won three more silver and four bronze medals to take its overall tally to 45. R.V. MOORTHY (REPORT: PAGE 16)

State govts. stumped by demography committee's 'religion-wise' inquiries

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

State governments are unable to answer most of the queries posed by a high-level panel studying demographic changes, as government departments do not ordinarily maintain much of the information sought by the panel on a religion-wise basis.

The High-Level Committee on Demographic Changes (HLCDC) under the Union Home Ministry has sought religion-wise data for the past 15 years on birth and vehicle registrations, school enrolment, and property transactions, as well as district-wise details of religious structures and unusual increases in Aadhaar, and voter ID, and ration card registrations. States have been asked to collate data on Hindus, Sikhs, Christians, Muslims, Parsis and Buddhists in all the categories.

State government officials told *The Hindu* that the set of 35 questions asked by the panel was difficult to answer as the secular construct of the Constitution prohibited the collection of data under religious categories.

Conversion among STs

The high-level panel has also sought intelligence assessments and commission reports on religious conversions among Scheduled Tribe communities, and details of operational detention centres, among other information.

Other than birth registration, where the religion of the newborn is mentioned on the certificate,

Unusual data

The HLCDC has sought religion-wise records from States for the past 15 years



Information sought on:

- Birth registration
- School enrolment
- Property transaction
- Vehicle registration
- Religious structures
- Voter registration

and the number of undocumented migrants apprehended or deported, the religion-wise data on all other categories were unavailable, said State government officials.

As the principal Opposition in 2006, the Bharatiya Janata Party had opposed the Sachar Commission recommendations and questioned its constitutional validity, stating that it promoted religious quota and was socially divisive. The commission was appointed by the Congress-led United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government in 2005 to look into the social, economic, and educational status of the Muslim community.

One of the questions of the HLCDC reads: "Details of districts showing unusual school enrolment trends inconsistent with historical birth rates, along with reasons". Another seeks district-wise data on religious structures (temples, mosques, churches, etc.) established in the past 15 years, including details of any GIS mapping or other technology used for their identification.

The HLCDC, led by retired Supreme Court judge Justice Prakash Prabhakar Naolekar was constituted by the Home Ministry on May 26 to study the demographic changes arising from illegal immigration and other abnormal reasons, and to suggest measures to deal with these demographic changes.

EC yet to provide data

On May 27, the Supreme Court while upholding the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise in Bihar, said that the Election Commission of India (EC) was well within its authority to verify citizenship to the limited extent of determining inclusion or exclusion from the electoral roll. The court directed the EC to refer, within the next four weeks, the names of electors who were part of the 2003 electoral roll but were purged in the Bihar SIR on the grounds of being non-citizens, to the Centre for adjudication by a competent authority under the Citizenship Act, 1955.

Government sources told *The Hindu* that the EC was yet to provide this data to the committee.

"We are yet to receive response from the State governments. A meeting was held with the EC officials last week, they are however yet to provide the data on people excluded from SIR on the grounds of being suspected foreign nationals staying here illegally," said a member of the committee on condition of anonymity. The EC did not respond to queries from *The Hindu* on the reasons for the delay in submission of the data to the panel.

Portion of mosque removed, clashes erupt

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

The police detained 15 persons, including five content creators, and registered seven FIRs in Madhya Pradesh's Ujjain on Monday after a group clashed with security personnel ahead of the demolition of a portion of the Shahi Mosque for a road-widening project, as part of preparations for the Simhashta Kumbh Mela in 2028. The situation is now peaceful, but heavy security arrangements remain in place in sensitive areas, officials told *The Hindu*. Clashes erupted when a



The police stand guard in front of the Shahi Mosque in Ujjain following a clash with protesters on Monday. REUTERS

few community members began removing a three-foot overhang of the mosque near the Mahakaleswar Temple following an agreement with the administration on Sunday night.

But another section started protesting against it. While the area around the mosque was barricaded, the group tried to reach the site and clashed with the security personnel. Some

security personnel were injured in stone-throwing.

Later, a Division Bench of the Madhya Pradesh High Court in Indore disposed of two petitions from Muslim representatives after they informed the court the matter had been settled with the Ujjain Municipal Corporation.

Ujjain Inspector General of Police, Rakesh Gupta, told *The Hindu* that the situation was brought under control by using mild force, including baton charge, and tear gas. A group also protested outside the residence of the city qazi Khaliq-ur-Rahman and threw stones, he said.

Broad-based uptick takes IIP growth to 8% in August

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Industrial growth in India quickened to 8% in August from 7.35% a month earlier, driven by a strong performance in the manufacturing, electricity, capital goods, and consumer goods sectors. The capital goods sector grew 16.9% while the consumer durables sector grew 11.1%.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 12

INBRIEF



Keralam launches second phase of anti-drug drive

Keralam Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala has called for collective action to keep the drug mafia away from society as the State government launched the second phase of its anti-drug campaign Operation Toofan on Monday. The Toofan Janajagratha Samithi was launched at Malabar Arts and Science College at Vengara, Malappuram. The second phase will focus on strengthening public participation through local bodies to prevent drug use and its spread. Mr. Chennithala said the participation of women had contributed to the success of the first phase as mothers could identify changes in children early.

SC to take up acquittal of 22 Sohrabuddin case accused

The Supreme Court on Monday agreed to examine a plea against the Bombay High Court order that upheld the acquittal of all 22 accused in the alleged fake encounter killings of gangster Sohrabuddin Shaikh, his wife Kausar Bi and aide Tulsiram Prajapati in 2005, while voicing concern that 92 witnesses had turned hostile. A Bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana issued notice on the plea filed by Nayabuddin Shaikh, brother of Sohrabuddin Shaikh, challenging the May 7 judgment of the High Court that acquitted 21 police personnel from Rajasthan and Gujarat and a farmhouse owner. PTI

IIT-B student suicide case: parents stage hunger strike, demand professor’s arrest

Yohaán Varghese
MUMBAI

The parents of IIT Bombay student Sahil Wakode, who died by suicide earlier this month, staged a hunger strike at Azad Maidan in Mumbai on Monday demanding the arrest of Professor Suryanarayana Doolla, who has been named in the FIR registered in connection with their son’s death.

Ravindra and Sonali Wakode began their protest at 10 a.m. and continued until around 6.30 p.m. They have now sought permission from the Azad Maidan police to resume their agitation from 9 a.m. on Tuesday. In a handwritten application submitted to the senior police inspector of the police station, advocate Nikhil Kamble, representing the family, sought permission for Mr. Ravindra Wakode to continue the



Sahil Wakode's parents on hunger strike in Mumbai on Monday. EMMANUAL YOGINI

protest on September 29 demanding justice for Sahil and Prof. Doolla’s arrest.

The family also questioned IIT Bombay’s internal inquiry into Sahil’s death, alleging that none of the members of the institute-appointed committee has contacted them so far. IIT Bombay constituted a 10-member committee to investigate the circumstances surrounding Sahil’s death. The panel,

which was initially given a week to complete its inquiry, has since been granted a one-week extension.

The case

Sahil, a second-year B.Tech student, died by suicide in his hostel room on September 18, hours after he sat for a mid-semester examination. Prof. Doolla was investigating the examination.

Following Sahil’s death, his parents alleged that he had faced caste-based discrimination and harassment at the institute. Police registered an FIR against the professor; the allegations are under investigation.

Meanwhile, IIT Bombay has relieved Prof. Doolla of his administrative responsibilities and sent him on leave pending the inquiries.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

Another POCSO case filed against granite baron Veeramani

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai police registered a fresh case against ‘Gem Granites’ R. Veeramani under the POCSO Act, police sources said on Monday.

The second case was registered on a complaint filed by a woman that her daughter, a minor, was sexually abused by the businessman. The Special Investigation Team (SIT) has taken up the probe in the case. The police booked Veeramani, 85, under the POCSO Act, and are likely to formally arrest him. Veeramani is currently lodged at the Puzhal prison in connection with a different POCSO case.

The police are investigating the statements given by three other women that they were subjected to sexual abuse by him in the past, sources said.

Veeramani is currently lodged at the Puzhal prison in connection with a different POCSO case

Investigators were also probing a complaint from a woman that her daughter, who was abused by Veeramani, had ended her life. The incident occurred years ago. The complainant said that though she had lodged a complaint with the police then, no action was taken, sources said. The police said those willing to file complaints relating to the above cases or share any information could call or send details on WhatsApp to 9345319676. The identity of the sender would be kept confidential.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on Tele-MANAS 14416)

Protesters demanding CEC’s resignation, cancellation of SIR clash with police in Patna

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Clashes erupted between police and protesters demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and cancellation of the special intensive review (SIR) of electoral rolls in Patna, Bihar, on Monday. The protest march began from the Gandhi Maidan towards Lok Bhawan (Governor residence).

‘CEC must step down’

Besides the Communist Party of India (CPI), members of the All India Students’ Federation (AISF), All India Youth Federation (AIYF), Bihar Mahila Samaj, Bihar State Kisan Sabha, Bharatiya Khet Mazdoor Union, All India Trade Union Congress (AITUC) and Tanzim-e-Insaf also took part in the demonstration.

A delegation of the protesters submitted a memorandum of their demands to the Bihar Governor

Students of Bihar University of Health Sciences, too, participated in the protest against delays in academic sessions and financial irregularities in the functioning of the institute.

Police had put barricades at city’s main Dak Bungalow thoroughfare, where they used the water cannon on the protesters, following which the the protesters clashed with the police.

“Protesters had turned out in large numbers and there were some antisocial elements too mingled with them to exploit the situation. They even clashed with police and indulged in stone pelting in which

some people sustained injuries as well. The traffic was completely paralysed by the protesters at the crossing”, said Patna Senior Superintendent of Police Kartikeya Sharma.

“I strongly condemn the police action, lathi-charge, use of water cannons on the CPI supported Badlaav Zaroori Hai - Raj Bhawan March in Patna, Bihar...,” CPI general secretary D. Raja posted on X.

A delegation of protesters later submitted a memorandum of their demands to the Governor, CPI said in a release.

The protesters demanded CEC Gyanesh Kumar’s resignation, cancellation of SIR, repeal of the Waqf (Amendment) Act, reinstatement of MGNREGS with 200 days of guaranteed work, and minimum wages, enactment of a comprehensive Central law for agricultural labourers, etc.

Few judicial officers make it to High Courts despite training and decades of experience

Soibam Rocky Singh
NEW DELHI

The elevation of seven district judges to the Delhi High Court recently has once again drawn attention to the narrow path from the subordinate judiciary to the higher Bench, where judicial officers account for only a fraction of the judges despite spending decades deciding cases at the trial-court level.

With Chief Justice D.K. Upadhyaya having administered the oath of office to the new judges, the Delhi High Court’s working strength has risen to 50 against a sanctioned strength of 60, of which 19 judges have been drawn from the subordinate courts.

While Article 217 of the Constitution provides two distinct streams for High

Court appointments – members of the Bar and judicial officers – it prescribes no fixed numerical ratio between them. However, a conventional norm has been that two-thirds of vacancies are drawn from the Bar while only one-third are from the judicial service cadre.

The origins of this skewed ratio go back to British rule, said Justice (retd.) R.K. Gauba, who rose from the subordinate cadre to serve on the Delhi High Court Bench.

“Under colonial rule, magisterial courts were predominantly manned by Indian Civil Service officers, focused heavily on *faujdari* (criminal) administration. They were not interested in *deewani* (civil) courts. The Constitution mandated a clear separation of the executive from

the judiciary, which led to the creation of independent State Judicial Services,” he told *The Hindu*.

“As the grassroots judiciary developed, logic dictated providing a structured career path. With two constitutional sources, the cake ought to have been divided equally if not more for the judicial services given their vast Bench experience,” he added.

Career bottlenecks

Most law graduates join the judicial service as civil judges in their late twenties. From there, it’s a slow climb. It usually takes about 10 years to become a senior civil judge, and another decade to reach the rank of a district and sessions judge.

Fleeting opportunity

By the time an officer enters the zone of considera-

Uphill climb

Judges elevated from subordinate courts comprise less than one-third of the sanctioned strength of several HCs

High Court	Sanctioned strength	Current strength	Elevated from judicial services
Tripura	5	4	2
Himachal Pradesh	17	15	6
Delhi	60	50	19
Bombay	94	75	16
Orissa	33	17	5
Telangana	42	27	5
Uttarakhand	11	8	1
Sikkim	3	2	0

Source: Department of Justice website
Data as of September 1; Delhi figures as of September 27

tion for elevation to the High Court, they are often in their late fifties, leaving them with just a few years before reaching the retirement age of 62.

This progression bottleneck also severely restricts their presence in the Supreme Court. The current

composition of the Supreme Court includes no sitting judges who began their careers in the trial court judiciary.

The last such appointment was Justice Bela M. Trivedi in August 2021, who retired in June 2025.

As per official data, the

one-third norm has also not been achieved in most States. Across the country’s sanctioned strength of 1,114 High Court judges, only 233 judges elevated from the district judiciary are currently in office.

The High Courts of Tripura (40%), Himachal Pradesh (35.29%) and Delhi (31.67%) exceed or come close to meeting the norm, even as other States lag far behind. Service judges constitute just 9.09% in the High Courts of Uttarakhand and Chhattisgarh, 11.90% in Telangana, 15.15% in Odisha and 17.02% in Bombay HC. Sikkim currently has zero representation from State Judicial Services.

In 2023, an application was moved by the Judicial Service Association of Delhi before the Supreme Court seeking a direction

to fill 50% of the seats in the High Court from the service quota.

However, in the order passed on April 25 of that year, a Bench of Justices B.R. Gavai, Vikram Nath and Sanjay Karol stated it was “not inclined to consider the prayer, leaving it open to the applicants to pursue the remedies before such forum as is permissible in law”. It directed the High Courts to recommend names from the service cadre before vacancies arose, noting that service judges often had only a few years of tenure in the High Courts.

Attracting talent

Former Principal District and Sessions Judge Pawan Kumar Jain told *The Hindu* that the lack of clear career progression discourages top law graduates from

joining the lower judiciary.

“If after serving 20 to 30 years one fails to reach the High Court at a reasonable age, the system will fail to attract brilliant minds. The institution must prioritise the litigant and fill vacancies efficiently,” he said.

Justice Gauba argued that filling High Court vacancies from the service cadre is significantly faster.

“With judicial officers, performance appraisals, integrity reports, and decades of judgment records are already available. Recommendations can be processed months in advance without leaving vacancies open for years. By reserving a disproportionate share for the Bar, we are ultimately depriving citizens of judges who are trained, experienced, and ready to deliver prompt justice,” he added.

INBRIEF



Two arrested after bike enters
convoy of V-P in Keralam

Two people have been arrested after a motorcycle allegedly entered the convoy of Vice-President C. P. Radhakrishnan near Kovalam during his visit to Thiruvananthapuram, Keralam, on Sunday. The Kanjiramkulam police identified the accused as Ashkar and Nadirsha, both of whom hail from Vallakkadavu. The two were allegedly under the influence of alcohol at the time of the incident. An investigation into the incident is under way. The police are examining the circumstances that led to the security lapse.

Elephant kills 60-year-old on
morning walk in Bengaluru

A 60-year-old man, who was on his morning walk with his daughter, was killed in an elephant attack near Mysuru Road in Bengaluru. The victim was identified as Nagaraju. N.R. Kamble, Range Forest Officer, Kaggalipura Range, said that the elephant reached the spot from the Bannerghatta Wildlife Sanctuary. “Our team is tracking the elephant,” he said. Deputy Conservator of Forests Y. Chakrapani said that steps would be taken to ensure that elephants do not stray beyond the Bannerghatta division.

Four women labourers killed
in accident in Telangana

Four women labourers were killed and three others were injured after a lorry collided head-on with the autorickshaw in which they were travelling in Mancherial district of Telangana on Monday. Minister G. Vivek Venkataswamy, expressed grief over the deaths and announced a financial aid of ₹25,000 each to the families of the deceased and ₹10,000 each to the injured.

Rain damages roads, crops in
A.P.; 71,700 farmers affected

Flood alerts issued for hundreds of villages in the State; in Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Konaseema district, people in island villages advised to vacate and avoid crossing the Godavari by traditional boats

Hareesh P.
VISAKHAPATNAM

Amid heavy rain induced by the deep depression over the Bay of Bengal, the Godavari Delta and Godavari Valley in Andhra Pradesh are bracing for floods for the second time in six days.

On Monday, the Sir Arthur Cotton Barrage at Dowleswaram in Rajamahendravaram continued to receive more than 9.7 lakh cusecs of water.

According to initial estimates, the rain damaged horticultural crops in over 1,734 hectares and agricultural crops in around 44,029 hectares.

State Agriculture Minister K. Atchannaidu said horticultural crops were affected in 89 mandals and 351 villages across 14 districts in Andhra Pradesh.



Severe damage: The paddy crop submerged in floodwater at a village in Srikakulam district of Andhra Pradesh on Monday. V. RAJU

According to preliminary estimates prepared by the Agriculture Department, crops in 1,229 villages across 190 mandals were damaged, affecting an estimated 71,796 farmers.

Roads and Buildings Minister B.C. Janardhan Reddy said an estimated 2,405 km of roads were damaged across the State, with the preliminary restoration

cost being put at ₹1,498.30 crore. The greatest extent of damage was reported in Srikakulam district, where 412 km of roads were affected, he said.

In Polavaram district, which is nestled between the Sabari and the Godavari, flood alerts have been issued for 171 villages. “As many as 55 motorboats and eight launches are

kept ready at Kunavaram and V.R. Puram for relief operations. By Monday, 17 habitations have been submerged,” said Integrated Tribal Development Agency Project Officer Subham Nokwal.

In Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Konaseema district, people in island villages have been advised to vacate and avoid crossing the Godavari by traditional boats.

In North Andhra, floodwaters are slowly receding in several villages of Srikakulam district. However, crops in Santabommali, Polaki, Meliaputti, Jalumuru and Burja villages were inundated by floodwaters from Vamsadhara, Nagavali, Bahuda and other rivers. The total loss was expected to be around ₹150 crore. At Allina in Burja mandal, paddy fields in 1,100 acres have been damaged.

Don't allow mines Act
to be implemented,
says Naveen as he
calls for united fight

The Hindu Bureau
BHUBANESWAR

The Biju Janata Dal (BJD) president and former Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik on Monday appealed the members of his party and other political parties not to allow the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, (MMDR Act) to be implemented in Odisha.

Leading a demonstration in front of the State Assembly, Mr. Patnaik launched an attack on the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) at the Centre and the State for their alleged “indifferent” mindset to understand the gravity of financial implication of the Act in the State.

“The MMDR Amendment Bill is not an ordinary Bill. It concerns the rights of the State. The people of Odisha are the rightful owners of Odisha’s mines and land. It is unfortunate that such an important Bill was passed in Parliament without any discussion. And why did our 20 BJP MPs remain silent? In whose interest?” he said.

“The State government also remained silent. Why? Out of fear of whom? I wrote to the Chief Minister seeking a special session of the Assembly. There was no response. I again wrote to the CM urging him to bring a resolution opposing the MMDR Amendment Act. But there was no response,” Mr. Patnaik



Naveen Patnaik

said. “This is a government that keeps saying “no” to everything. Because of this Act, Odisha will suffer losses amounting to thousands of crores of rupees every year,” said Mr. Patnaik.

“I will fight for Odisha’s rights till my last breath. I appeal to everyone, and I appeal to all political parties to join in this struggle. Let us come together for this land and make a resolve that we will not allow the MMDR Amendment Act to be implemented in Odisha,” he said.

Speaking on the occasion, Sujata Rout, former IAS officer inducted recently into BJD and wife of V.K. Pandian, close aide of Mr. Patnaik, said, “The revenue generated from the mineral sector could have funded irrigation, education, farmer welfare and infrastructure projects. We could have progressed Odisha by 10 years. By supporting the passage of the Bill in the Parliament, the BJP MPs returned the fund that came knocking our doors.”

Police told to tighten Keralam CM's security

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Intelligence wing of Kerala police has directed District Police Chiefs to strengthen security arrangements for Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan at public functions and travels.

It cited concerns over uncontrolled crowds, including presspersons, who approach Mr. Satheesan



V.D. Satheesan

and come into physical contact with him.

In a confidential alert is-

sued on Saturday, the Additional Director-General of Police (Intelligence) cautioned that such situations could result in serious security lapses, considering that the Chief Minister belongs to the highest security category in the State.

Besides uniformed personnel, police officers in plainclothes must be deployed to prevent untoward incidents and ensure his complete security, the

order stated. The instructions come against the backdrop of recent instances in which presspersons were allegedly prevented from approaching the Chief Minister at public engagements.

Senior officials of the Kochi City police reportedly prevented presspersons from posing questions to Mr. Satheesan when he arrived to participate in a function on September 26.

Picking up pieces



Life of uncertainty: Ragpickers search for useful items such as iron and wood among undissolved parts of Ganesh idols days after their immersion at the Prakasam Barrage in Vijayawada on Monday. GIRI K.V.S.

Karnataka to submit final report
on drought situation in a few days

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Karnataka government is expected to submit its final memorandum on the prevailing drought to the Centre in the first week of October, after the monsoon ends on September 30.

Deputy Chief Minister G. Parameshwara said the ground-truthing exercise was currently under way in several taluks, following which the final memorandum detailing the extent of losses and the compensation sought would be submitted to the Centre.

He added that the three Inter-Ministerial Central



Parched land: Three Central teams will arrive in Karnataka on October 3 for a drought study. S.K. DINESH

Teams arriving in Karnataka on October 3 for a drought study would assess the situation based on the first memorandum submitted to the Centre.

A day after the Opposition Bharatiya Janata Party

(BJP) and Janata Dal (Secular) announced their decision not to be part of the all-party delegation to the Centre seeking drought relief, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said it showed that the BJP was indulging

in a “drama of deceit” and asserted that the State government would take all necessary steps for the welfare of farmers.

He also announced that an all-party meeting would be convened to discuss the drought situation and the K. Kasturirangan Committee report.

“Just because the Opposition does not join the delegation, the State government will not ignore the interests of farmers. The State government will do whatever is needed to protect their interests. It shows that they (BJP) are not interested in the welfare of farmers,” the Chief Minister said on Monday.

Kerala HC flays AMMA, asks
if it will need a special court
to hear pleas from members

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court has expressed criticism over the high number of petitions arising from disputes between members of the Association of Malayalam Movie Artists (AMMA).

The court made the observation while considering a petition to quash the first information report lodged against actor Lakshmi Priya and others based on a complaint filed by fellow actor Ansiba Hassan.

Response to plea

Justice Jobin Sebastian sought the State’s response to a petition filed by Ms. Lakshmi Priya, her hus-



The Kerala HC was considering a petition to quash FIR lodged against actor Lakshmi Priya.

band, P. Jayesh, and Thripunithura Vanitha Cell Sub-Inspector Reshma. “Will we need special courts to hear cases arising from disputes within AMMA? The problems of the common people lie in wait, as we clear these issues,” the court said.

Ms. Lakshmi Priya initially lodged a complaint alleging that Ms. Hassan, through a WhatsApp message, had caused family disputes between her and Mr. Jayesh. In this regard, Ms. Hassan was summoned by Ms. Reshma, who informed her that a case had been registered based on Ms. Lakshmi Priya’s complaint.

Subsequently, Ms. Hassan filed a complaint, alleging that “the accused unlawfully summoned her, wrongfully restrained her, intimidated and compelled her to sign a statement, prepared and utilised records adverse to her interests and damaged her reputation”.

Abdul Latheef Naha
PALAKKAD

The drumbeat that once carried royal orders through village streets, and later announced the attachment of properties, will no longer be heard outside Keralam’s courts. The archaic practice is now set to pass into history. The Kerala High Court’s Rules Committee has decided to remove the provision for the traditional “tom-tom” and “kinnam mutti vilambaram” used to inform the public about property attachment proceedings. The change follows a campaign by rights activist Boban

Mattumanta, who questioned the need for a colonial-era practice at a time when notices, newspapers, television and social media can reach far more people. The tom-toming tradition goes back to the days of princely rule. When the king had an order to announce, officials would gather people in markets and other public places. A drumbeat would draw attention before the order was read out. The British later adopted a similar method to make property



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

attachment proceedings public.

The practice continued under Sub-rule 2 of Rule 54 of Order XXI of the Code of Civil Procedure, 1908. While drum-beating had largely disappeared

from district courts in Palakkad, Thiruvananthapuram, Ernakulam and Kozhikode, the beating of a metal plate continued in some places. The announcements were also entered in court records.

Its charges

There was even a charge for it. Information obtained under the Right to Information Act showed that the Palakkad District Court, Sub Court and Munsiff Court collected ₹56,600 as “tom-tom charges” between January and October 2022. It was in 2016 that the tom-tom charges were increased

from ₹15 to ₹100. “It is strange that no one questioned this archaic practice even in 2016, when the tom tom charge was raised from ₹15 to ₹100. It shows how lethargic our system had become,” said Mr. Mattumanta.

For centuries, the sound of drums and metal plates served one purpose: to make sure that a court announcement did not go unheard. But times have changed. With the provision now being removed, a practice that began with royal proclamations and survived through the colonial and modern judicial systems is finally falling silent.

How can children have social media accounts, asks SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday questioned how Indian children can have accounts on social media platforms, given that these accounts are activated on the basis of contracts drawn up between the children and the platforms despite the fact that minors are legally incompetent to enter contracts under Indian law.

Such contracts are completely void from the beginning or void *ab initio*, noted a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant.

“What are these social media platforms doing? Are they permitting children as young as 12 years to 15 years to have accounts? And what is an ‘account’? It is a contract between the social media platform and a child,” Justice Joymalya Bagchi said, addressing the Union government side, represented by Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta.

Digital safeguards

The court was hearing a plea filed by the NGO Just Rights for Children Alliance (JRCA), represented by senior advocate H.S.



The SC said the government should ensure that platforms conform to the 18-year rule.

Phoolka, seeking safeguards for children accessing social media.

The Solicitor-General submitted that the issue raised in the petition was, *prima facie*, covered by the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, but Mr. Phoolka argued that they come into force only in 2027.

Justice Bagchi, addressing the law officer, said that the government should pass some directions under the Intermediary Rules, ensuring that platforms conform to the 18-year minimum threshold.

Justice Bagchi said a statutory framework has to be molded, using existing laws to specifically address these issues.

SC questions govt’s power to levy UPI merchant fees

If it is not a tax or fee, what is the executive scope of making this expropriation, Justice Joymalya Bagchi asks; Supreme Court refuses repeated pleas to grant an interim stay on its implementation

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday questioned the government’s legal authority to “expropriate” 0.4% charge from merchants for specified UPI person-to-merchant transactions in excess of ₹2,000.

A three-judge Bench headed by the Chief Justice of India Surya Kant issued notice to the Union of India, the Reserve Bank of India, and the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) on a petition alleging that the UPI merchant discount rate (MDR) charges would trigger a return to cash transactions, and the bane of black money.

But the court refused petitioner Anjan Datta’s repeated pleas to grant an interim stay on the implementation of the September 14, 2026 notification. The Bench directed the government, the Central banker and the NPCI, which will introduce the UPI MDR charges from October 15, 2026.

“We are on the legal incidence of your notification. If it is not a tax or fee, what is the executive scope of making this expropriation? We want an explanation in an affidavit... If not a fee, what is its character?” Justice Joymalya Bagchi asked Additional Solicitor General N. Venkataraman, appearing for the Centre.



Taking a toll: Centre has introduced a merchant discount rate fee of 0.4% on person-to-merchant UPI payments over ₹2,000. REUTERS

An MDR of 0.4% would be introduced on Person-to-Merchant (P2M) UPI transactions above ₹2,000, according to the government. For transactions of ₹75,000 and above, the MDR would be capped at ₹300 per transaction.

Mr. Venkataraman submitted that the charges would touch a “scarce, thin” population. “This [UPI MDR charges] is yet to come. It is likely to come on October 15. I have to say that 96% of people using the gateway are exempted. Amongst the remaining 4%, essential services are capped at ₹5. There is also a value cap – any threshold to the merchant beyond ₹75,000 is capped at ₹300. Collection charges are less than 0.5% with all these limitations,” he submitted.

But the law officer said the MDR charges would be

limited to only the aggregators and banks. The government hardly had a role.

“Aggregators and banks are the entities that ensure instantaneous credit and debit happen, to avoid cash transactions in the economy. It is their ecosystem. They alone operate there. The government does not take anything. This is a purely administrative mechanism. The government is several steps away from this money. My Lords have to bear all this in mind,” Mr. Venkataraman submitted.

The Bench gave the respondents four weeks to file their counter affidavits.

The petition has also challenged the constitutional validity of the amended Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, alleging that it gave unguided powers to the Executive to decide which electronic payment modes would receive the no-charge protection. The petitioner pointed out that the no-charge protection for RuPay debit cards would continue without a monetary ceiling.

Ease third language evaluation norms for Class 6, says SC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court (SC) on Monday directed the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) to extend to Class 6 students the same relaxation available to those in Class 7 regarding evaluation under the three-language formula.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant passed the order after Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta representing the Union government and the CBSE along with Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, submitted that the Centre would attempt to persuade the court to allow implementation for Class 6 itself.

Class 7 students, along with those in Classes 8 and 9, have been granted a transitional relaxation from the CBSE Board exam in the third language when they reach Class 10. The third language will be assessed only through internal school-based evaluation, with no pass or fail linked to Board results.

Hearing the petitions challenging the three-language scheme, the court had, in previous hearings,



The third language will be assessed only through internal school-based evaluation. ANI

asked the law officers to seek instructions on whether the current batch of Class 6 students could be exempted from the scheme.

Mr. Mehta, on Monday, said the impact of the scheme would be minimal. He said except for 1.2% of 28,819 schools, the others had attuned themselves to the demands of the scheme. The Solicitor-General said the children would “adapt”. But Justice Joymalya Bagchi, on the Bench, responded that it was not about children’s prowess to adapt, but they should be “comfortable”.

Justice Bagchi said if any school held back a student in internal assessment, the court would intervene.

Coast Guard averts major oil spill off Odisha’s coast, rescues Belize-flagged ship

The Hindu Bureau
BHUBANESWAR

The Indian Coast Guard (ICG) on Monday said it averted a major incident off the Odisha coast, rescuing a distressed foreign vessel, *MT Seagull 9*, approximately 37 nautical miles east-southeast of Paradip and prevented a major oil spill.

The Belize-flagged vessel, carrying 9,000 tonnes of palm oil with 23 crew members aboard, issued a distress call at 7.30 a.m. on September 27 following the main engine failure and rapid ballast tank flooding, which caused the ship to tilt dangerously, the ICG said in a statement.

ICGS Vishwast was immediately pressed into service. “A specialist ICG damage control team boarded the unstable vessel under challenging conditions.



MT Seagull 9. @INDIACOASTGUARD

Deploying submersible deflooding pumps and advanced damage-control equipment, the team swiftly arrested the leakage, blanked two damaged seawater pipelines, and contained a third fractured line,” it said.

The ICG had also diverted a Pollution Control Vessel (PCV) and an additional Offshore Patrol Vessel (OPV) to the location for augmented pollution response and round-the-clock monitoring of the situation.

ICGS Vishwast’s special-

ised team, in coordination with the vessel’s crew, carried out concurrent cargo transfer and de-flooding operations, effectively stabilising the tanker and eliminating the threat of capsizing.

Aerial surveillance

A Dornier aircraft was used for real-time aerial surveillance. “A minor palm oil sheen initially observed near the vessel on September 27 was confirmed fully dissipated during the follow-up aerial sorties on September 28. Strict pollution-response protocols remain active to safeguard the marine ecosystem,” the ICG said.

“In a synchronised multi-agency effort, Paradip Port Authority tug Dolphin took the stabilised *MT Seagull 9* under tow towards the anchorage area off Paradip,” it added.

India’s bullet train project didn’t meet early expectations, says Japan official

Kallol Bhattacharjee
TOKYO

The rate of progress on the Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed rail corridor project has not “lived up to” Japan’s initial expectations, a senior official of Japan’s Ministry of Foreign Affairs said on Monday. India’s first bullet train project is being supported, financially and technically, by Japan.

Speaking exclusively to *The Hindu*, the official said that Japan is not in a position to declare when the project will be completed, but maintained that, despite the delay, the project is now making “steady progress”.

India and Japan will convene the “two plus two” dialogue by the end of the year, the official said.

On the issue of disputed territories, the Japanese official asserted that all countries “must respect international maritime laws in the South China Sea and



Fits and starts: The senior official said Japan is not in a position to declare when the project will be completed. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

the East China Sea”, including in the Senkaku islands that Japan claims as part of its sovereign territories and China claims as the Diaoyu islands.

No concrete timeline

“I have to admit the timeline has not lived up to our expectations as originally envisaged,” the official said, with regard to the Mumbai-Ahmedabad rail project. However, he expressed confidence that the project is now “moving

forward”. After years of feasibility studies and reviews, the project was kicked off on September 14, 2017, when Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the late Japanese PM Shinzo Abe laid its foundation stone in Ahmedabad.

“Both sides are committed to bringing high-speed trains to India, among other things. Construction of high-speed infrastructure is also developing steadily on the ground both in Mumbai and Gujarat, and

we hope high-speed trains will start to move in a few years in India,” the official said, without giving a concrete timeline for the project’s completion.

His comments come months after former Japanese Minister Hideki Maki-hara blamed the delay on the “sheer recklessness” of Indian officials, adding that Japan had been excluded from key safety components, such as the signalling system. Asked by *The Hindu* about Mr. Maki-hara’s remarks, the official said, “I don’t want to endorse any comments outside of the negotiation.” He said that Japan was going ahead with works related to on the “signal system, rail structure.”

The “two plus two” dialogue featuring the Foreign and Defence Ministers of both nations will be held by the end of the year, the official said, adding that the official announcement of the meeting is expected to come within a month.

Cong. leaders arrested for defacing wall of CEC’s home

Press Trust of India
AGRA

Two Congress leaders were arrested on Monday for allegedly defacing the wall and the main gate of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar’s home in Agra with the words “*Gyanesh Gaddar, Gyanesh Chor*” (Gyanesh traitor, Gyanesh thief), the police said.

Agra Assistant Commissioner of Police Bajrang Prasad said a case was registered at the Hari Parvat police station in connection with the incident and Congress leaders Mukesh Dhangar and Anil Yadav were arrested.

The protesters, including Congress workers and members of affiliated organisations, arrived at Mr. Kumar’s residence in large numbers in the morning, and also put up stickers and pasted pamphlets outside the residence.

40 modules connected to Bhatti gang busted: Shah

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

More than 40 modules linked to the Shahzad Bhatti network, allegedly involved in cross-border smuggling of weapons, explosives, and narcotics, have been busted and 350 people arrested across 15 States, Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on Monday.

Mr. Shah said more than 100 First Information Reports had been registered against members of the network and that the Union government had declared the Shahzad Bhatti network a terrorist organisation under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). Bhatti is a Pakistani social media influencer.

J&K Assembly passes resolution on Statehood; BJP MLAs stage walkout

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Amid uproar from BJP legislators and opposing “official communiques from the J&K Law Secretary and the Chief Secretary”, the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly on Monday passed a resolution seeking the restoration of “full Statehood”, with around 60 of the 90 legislators supporting it.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah warned against linking the restoration of Statehood to the end of militancy, saying it “unfortunately leaves our case before Islamabad and not New Delhi”.

Sloganeering, protests in the well of the House, disruptions and a walkout by the 29 BJP legislators



BJP MLAs walk out of the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly on Monday after the House passed a resolution on Statehood. PTI

marked the proceedings. The Assembly met in the morning to discuss the resolution moved by Mr. Abdullah on September 25. BJP legislator R.S. Pathania submitted a notice to Speaker Abdul Rahim Rather and sought his removal, saying that “if the

greater autonomy resolution was passed he (Mr. Rather) would no longer be eligible to occupy the chair”.

Except for the BJP, all political parties, including the ruling National Conference (NC) ally Congress and the CPI(M) and non-al-

lies the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP), the J&K Peoples Conference (JKPC), the Awami Ittehad Party (AIP) and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), supported the resolution.

Mr. Abdullah said the resolution was “only on Statehood”. “It’s a carefully written resolution because we knew the BJP would try to disrupt the House and not participate in voting. Where in the resolution do we seek voting on Article 370, 35A or special status? We are seeking a vote on Statehood. Unfortunately, my own colleagues, who brought amendments to insert Article 370 and 35A, fall for the BJP’s trap. I urge them not to press for amendments. It provides an excuse to the BJP,” he said.

T.N. CM launches gold-ring gift scheme for newborns

C. Palanivel Rajan
MADURAI

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Monday launched the *Thaimaaman Thanga Mothiram Thittam* in Madurai, marking a Statewide rollout of one of his Assembly poll promises.

Under the State-sponsored scheme, a one gram gold ring will be gifted to every baby born in government hospitals and primary health centres across Tamil Nadu. The scheme is being implemented with retrospective effect to cover babies born in government hospitals from June 22, 2026 (Mr. Vijay’s birthday) onwards.

On day one, Mr. Vijay personally presented gold



T.N. CM C. Joseph Vijay presents a gold ring to a newborn in Madurai on Monday. PTI

rings to 37 newborns, moving through the main auditorium and the Comprehensive Emergency Obstetric and Newborn Care ward at the hospital.

At the launch event, mothers belonging to three different religions were seated on the stage with their children. Mr. Vijay first adorned these three children – Yazhini, a baby

girl born to the couple Muthu and Muniyandi; Mohammed Sainsha, a baby boy born to the couple Sikandar and Ramila Banu; and a baby girl named Joman born to the couple Bose and Stella Mary – with gold rings.

Health Minister K.G. Arunraj, participating at the event, said the scheme embodies a “sacred cultural bond” between a maternal uncle (*Thaimaaman* in Tamil) and a child.

He noted that the State strengthened maternal and child health through robust medical infrastructure, skilled personnel, and priority schemes such as financial assistance, emergency obstetric care, nutritional support, free deliveries, and newborn care.

Rare-disease drugs can be India’s next pharma frontier

After affordable drugs, India’s next challenge is to show the world how to make rare-disease drugs accessible; with a streamlined regulatory pathway and government procurement, India could build a globally competitive rare-disease pharmaceutical sector

Gayatri Saberwal
Rakesh Mishra
Alok Bhattacharya

Each rare disease affects very few people. However, there are around 8,000 rare diseases, and they cumulatively affect hundreds of millions of people. In India, 1,004 rare genetic disorders have been reported so far.

It used to be that because the number of patients for a rare-disease drug was very small, so the pharmaceutical industry’s interest in developing such drugs was limited. Therefore they were called orphan drugs.

In order to overcome this hesitancy, many governments have incentivised companies to develop orphan drugs. Examples include the Orphan Drug Act, which the U.S. passed in 1983 to provide tax incentives, seven years of market exclusivity for the first approved product for a given condition, grants, regulatory fee waivers, etc. That is, it reduced the costs of developing the drugs and enabled companies to make a good profit.

This allowed companies to diversify into rare-disease drugs. Before the passage of the Orphan Drug Act, only 38 relevant drugs had been approved in the U.S. But after that, by 2022, there had been 1,122 approvals. Subsequently, several countries and regions, including Japan, Australia, and the European Union had approved similar legislation encouraging pharmaceutical companies to develop and manufacture orphan drugs.

Because of the small market, companies tend to set very high prices for these medications, and it is not unusual for a rare disease patient to find that a year’s worth of the drug costs around \$100,000 (₹1 crore) or more. This puts the medication out of reach for virtually all patients around the world unless a health insurance scheme or government health service covers it.

Samples of such high-priced pharmaceuticals are described in the table.

The challenges

Although the Government of India supports rare disease patients with up to a total of ₹50 lakh for their treatment, this is often insufficient to cover the necessary costs even for a year, and patients may have to resort to crowdfunding to raise the required capital.

For example, in mid-2025, ₹9 crore was raised through crowdfunding to pay for gene therapy for a 16-month-old child in Kolkata. In fact, almost 4,000 children are listed on a Government of India crowdfunding platform, with the cumulative annual cost of treatment for these patients amounting to over ₹9,000 crore.

Many drugs for rare diseases have been developed, but they cater to only about 5% of rare diseases and associated conditions. Therefore, most patients lack suitable drugs, even those available at high cost.

The two key challenges in developing new orphan drugs are identifying a patient cohort for conducting clinical trials and determining endpoints in these trials. Once a drug is approved, undertaking small-scale manufacturing and distribution that is affordable and of high-quality are other major challenges.

In this article, the authors present here a possible solution to these issues. These solutions touch on how foreign companies that tend to develop novel drugs can work with India both for clinical trials and manufacturing.

Trials for new drugs

With an overall population exceeding 1.4 billion, India has a large number of patients with any given condition. And due to high rates of endogamy in certain social groups, the prevalence of a particular rare disease is even higher than might be expected based on its prevalence elsewhere.

For example, research has shown that in particular ethnic groups, the prevalence of beta-thalassemia in India can be 10.5% whereas, per a 2023 review, the prevalence in India’s general population is 3.7%. Indian patients have also become increasingly organised in recent years, with a proliferation of patient advocacy groups focusing on specific diseases.

On the research front, for example, one longitudinal study has been tracking a group of 70 people with a rare condition called GNE myopathy. Patient groups pertaining to Rett syndrome have a

Some expensive drugs for rare diseases

Drug	Generic name	Therapy type	Disease	One-time/Annual treatment	Price (USD)
Lenmeldy	Atidarsagene autotemcel	Stem cell gene therapy	Metachromatic leukodystrophy	One-time	4.25 million
Hemgenix	Etranacogene dezaparvovec	Gene therapy	Haemophilia B	One-time	3.5 million
Elevidys	Delandistrogene moxeparvovec	Gene therapy	Duchenne muscular dystrophy	One-time	3.2 million
Zokinvi	Ionafarnib	Small molecule	Hutchinson-Gilford progeria and ultra-rare laminopathies	Annual	1-1.2 million/year
Skyclarys	Omaveloxolone	Small molecule	Friedreich’s ataxia	Annual	370,000/year
Trikafta	Combination of elexacaftor, ivacaftor, tezacaftor	Small molecule	Cystic fibrosis	Annual	200,000-300,000/year

Source: Authors provided



In India, the government supports rare disease patients with up to a total of ₹50 lakh for their treatment; however, this is often insufficient to cover the necessary costs and patients may have to resort to crowdfunding to raise the required capital

registry of more than 400 patients. The gene pool of the Indian diaspora also has unique mutations, often across different ethnicities.

In all, there is a large number of rare disease patients, which should help in finding a suitable patient cohort for trials. However, patients in India are not usually participants in international trials for orphan drugs. Therefore, there is considerable scope to increase their involvement in such trials. The government could foster the collaboration of foreign companies and local organisations, as it does in the area of chip manufacturing. It also could invite multinational drug companies to set up drug-development centres vis-à-vis rare diseases in India, in collaboration with patient groups.

If Indian patients are important participants in developing such drugs, they are also likely to be more interested in accessing the resulting drugs than in any monetary compensation. Put another way, Indian patients may be willing to help drug development but only if they see themselves as beneficiaries of the approved drugs.

Overpriced drugs that they cannot access serve no local purpose. To this end, the authors propose that India decide on the price of drugs sold within the country or in the Global South. The company developing the drug can be free to set prices in the rest of the world.

The authors say this with reference to the concept of benefit-sharing. Recently, country representatives and medical experts discussed this concept in the context of the Pandemic Agreement of the World Health Organization (WHO). The idea is that in the event of a pandemic, countries will rapidly share information about pathogens, including their genetic information, with the rest of the world. That way, pharmaceutical and biotechnology companies can develop diagnostics, drugs, and vaccines as early as possible. The catch is such products must be shared across countries, fairly

and equitably.

Notably, U.S. and Chinese companies are locked in a charged race to develop drugs for rare diseases. Chinese companies will usually have access to enough patients, and also to low-cost manufacturing. Likewise, companies from the Western nations may find it worthwhile to explore opportunities of collaboration in India.

Manufacturing in India

India has been called the “pharmacy of the world” due to its production of small molecule generics, which fill 47% of the prescriptions for generics in the U.S. India also has the largest number of manufacturing sites approved by U.S. regulators outside the U.S.

Indian firms also manufacture and export biosimilars to the U.S. and the European Union and supply 15% of all biosimilars sold in the U.S. Of late, facilities in the country have been producing a relatively novel therapy personalised to each patient for particular cancers, called CAR-T, to international standards.

In effect, India can manufacture various categories of high-quality drugs at low cost. Local manufacturers are also ready to do this for small volumes, whereas manufacturers in Western nations are often unwilling to do so.

Under Rule 101 of the New Drugs and Clinical Trials Rules 2019, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) has specified six countries – including the U.S. and the U.K.; if one of these countries approves a drug, the drug need not have a new clinical trial conducted in India before its maker seeking the Indian regulator’s approval.

This provision can be a major incentive to manufacture and market certain generic drugs in India. However, this policy can benefit from greater transparency, including guidance documents to help drug developers and sponsors file applications to the regulator. Regulatory agencies abroad routinely develop such documents to ease the applications process.

As a rule, the approval of such drugs should be based on bioequivalence, i.e. their behaviour in the body should be the same as that of the original drug; safety and toxicity studies; and the drug’s effectiveness once it is on the market.

Such a pathway will require appropriate safeguards for quality, safety, a system that looks out for adverse events after the drug is on the market (i.e.

pharmacovigilance), and manufacturing standards – but it will also considerably reduce the need for duplicate paperwork.

What the state can do

We also have an opportunity to take advantage of India’s expertise in generic drugs to create a global orphan drug manufacturing industry. The government should draft policy that reduces the financial barriers to producing such drugs locally. A useful model could be developed along the lines of the production-linked incentive schemes for manufacturing. That is, companies investing in the manufacture of selected orphan drugs could receive incentives linked to production, investment, exports, and patient access.

The financial incentives could include tax incentives for investing in orphan drug manufacturing and production-linked incentives for approved orphan drugs. Other kinds of support could include support for technology transfer and process development in collaboration with a national laboratory, advanced market commitments (AMCs) by the government, committing to buy a certain output at a certain price point, and distributing it through the Centres of Excellence on Rare Diseases, the Central Government Health Scheme, and the Pradhan Mantri Bhartiya Jan Aushadhi Kendras. Manufacturers could also benefit from predictable demand during the early stages of production, and incentives for exporting to low- and middle-income countries.

The overall objective should not simply be to subsidise companies. Instead, the government should de-risk the initial investment enough to make orphan drug manufacturing commercially viable.

With a streamlined regulatory pathway, appropriate financial incentives, and government procurement, India could build a globally competitive rare-disease pharmaceutical sector.

Taken together, India has already shown the world how to make drugs affordable.

The next challenge is to show the world how to make rare-disease drugs accessible.

(Gayatri Saberwal, Rakesh Mishra, and Alok Bhattacharya are with the Tata Institute for Genetics and Society. Bhattacharya is also with ‘World Without GNE Myopathy’. gayatri.saberwal@gmail.com, rakesh.mishra@tigs.res.in, alok.bhattacharya@gmail.com)



Muhammad Zeeshan Ali and Khurram Daud (right). GOVT. OF PAKISTAN/FACEBOOK

China brings Pakistani astronauts closer to orbit

Reuters

Two Pakistani pilots are memorising Mandarin, spinning in centrifuge drills, and learning to eat, sleep and repair equipment while weightless as a decision nears on which one will become the first foreign astronaut aboard China’s Tiangong space station.

The voyage into space would be a first for the South Asian nation. It is part of broader cooperation with Beijing that straddles the Belt and Road Initiative and has produced Chinese-launched Pakistani satellites, a joint satellite-navigation system and a Pakistani-built rover due to fly on China’s Chang’e 8 lunar mission around 2028.

Pilots Zeeshan Ali and Khurram Daud have spent months training at the China Astronaut Research and Training Center in Beijing for a mission that was conceived by the two countries in 2019, said Amer Gilani, who oversees human spaceflight cooperation at Pakistan’s space agency, SUPARCO.

China has not said which of the two will fly or when, but Gilani said a final astronaut selection decision is expected in mid-to-late October.

Whoever is chosen will not return to Pakistan before launch, setting off into space directly from training in China and returning home after a recovery period following the return to Earth, Gilani said in an interview.

The astronaut will fly aboard a Chinese-built spacecraft, launched from a Chinese site, trained by Chinese instructors and communicating in Mandarin in orbit

Training includes intensive Chinese-language instruction, learning spacecraft systems, and adapting to both the microgravity of orbit and the g-forces of liftoff, he added.

The details shared by Gilani and SUPARCO’s director of artificial intelligence Uzair Ansari are the first insight provided by SUPARCO to foreign media since the pilots were selected and deployed to China.

Once in space, the chosen pilot will carry the title of “payload specialist”, which is astronaut-speak for someone whose job in orbit is running Pakistan’s science experiments rather than flying the ship, Ansari said.

Of more than 300 proposals SUPARCO fielded from universities in Karachi, Lahore and Islamabad after a year-long campaign, Gilani said Chinese institutes picked four for this flight: biotechnology experiments that will help combat food insecurity and climate change.

Every experiment is built and pre-tested in SUPARCO’s own labs before Chinese engineers sign off.

The scientific payload is modest next to a station that has already hosted more than 180 experiments and produced over 500 research papers and 150 patents, Ansari added.

Tiangong’s three modules weigh about 77 metric tonnes combined and house roughly 14 experiment racks spanning life sciences, materials, fluid physics, combustion and radiation exposure, Gilani said.

The astronaut will fly aboard a Chinese-built spacecraft, launched from a Chinese site, trained by Chinese instructors and communicating in Mandarin in orbit.

The Pakistani astronaut is due to return with two members of a Chinese crew that arrived at the space station in May because the third member is expected to stay for a year to enable the study of long-duration human physiology in space.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Daily page’



Light on truth

No government intent on working for the people should fear transparency

Protests by political parties and transparency activists have derailed the surreptitious rollout, in Tamil Nadu, of a regressive decision to exempt the Public (Law and Order) Department from the purview of the Right to Information Act, 2005. On September 21, the State government issued a Government Order (G.O.) exercising powers under Section 24 (4) of the RTI Act to notify the department as an “intelligence and security organisation” to which the provisions of the Act shall not apply. While the G.O. surfaced in the public domain only on September 27, strikingly, the Public Department’s designated authorities under the RTI Act had instantly begun citing it to deny information to applicants as early as September 22. This betrayed a system that is shy of investing in transparency. Unsurprisingly, State Law Minister C.T.R. Nirmalkumar was initially defensive about the government’s unilateral decision, which, in any case, required the State to have it placed before the legislature (Section 24 (5), RTI Act). He claimed that the ambit of the exemption was not sweeping enough to shield the entire department, but was intended to prevent the sharing of sensitive information relating to district-level inquiries into incidents of communal clashes and the like. However, shortly thereafter, he announced the G.O.’s withdrawal, without explaining why.

While the State’s afterthought is welcome, the episode has again exposed the political class’s penchant for maintaining secrecy in administrative affairs. Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, whose promise of change came as a breath of fresh air, should have known better. It is concerning that the establishment desired to insulate itself from transparency by amending an Act which, in any case, emphatically enables non-disclosure of information through a long list of exemptions under Section 8. Even otherwise, designated information officers of central/State institutions have displayed an uncanny skill in being economical with the truth, delaying responses or bouncing off queries from RTI Act applicants, citing vague reasons. Besides, concerns about the Digital Personal Data Protection Act diluting the RTI Act further have been widely articulated. It is worrying that the Satrak Nagrik Sangathan’s 2024-25 report card on Information Commissions found a backlog of over 41,000 appeals and complaints before the Tamil Nadu State Information Commission (TNSIC), as of June last year. Yet, the TNSIC is functioning with only half of its sanctioned eight Information Commissioners and has no Chief Information Commissioner. Instead of seeking to defeat the intent of a piece of legislation enacted to empower citizens with access to information, the Tamil Nadu government would do well to strengthen the TNSIC. After all, only an administration that does not fear transparency can be the true harbinger of change.

Waves of rain

Odisha must prepare for repeated bouts of intense downpour

Odisha is experiencing one of its most intense monsoons, recording 1,453 mm of rainfall between June and September 25 this year, a 29% excess. The reason is the unusually large number of atmospheric systems, including 11 over the Bay of Bengal, the latest making landfall near Kalingapatnam on September 23. The IMD had forecast that India would receive 90% of the long-period average partly because an El Niño was expected to develop; the State had finished June itself with a 47% deficit. However, rainfall in the region came to be dominated by the weather systems, which also repeatedly delivered rain without giving locals time to recover. By the State’s estimates, 5.2 lakh people had been affected by July 30 and another 13.5 lakh by August 27. At least 60 locations have so far received more than 100 mm of rain in 24 hours, with the runoff swelling multiple rivers and threatening more floods downstream, including in Bhadrak and Jajpur, and landslides in hilly areas. When a previous bout of rain has already saturated the soil and topped local storage, a new bout could lead more immediately to runoff. While the State’s south is predominantly highland and confronts slope failure risks, its coast is a depositional plain of multiple deltas, rendering a terrain with low gradient through which water does not readily drain into the sea.

The efficacy of the State’s long-standing policy to have zero casualties remains to be seen, especially given the extent to which the ongoing season will stress the drain design and maintenance deficiencies that the CAG had flagged in 2024. Other important data include the eventual crop and infrastructure damage assessments and the peak levels of the Baitarani, Budhabalanga, Jalka, and Rushikulya rivers after the 11th system fades. A study in May by the Odisha University of Agriculture and Technology, based on data from 1901-2020, reported that both maximum one-day and five-day rainfall bursts were becoming more common even as the frequency of heavy-rain days was dipping. The State has been renowned for its disaster management protocols. However, the recurrent waterlogging in urban hubs such as Berhampur and the disruption of inter-State highways and rail networks suggest that its evacuation protocols outpace its civic engineering, with significant room to improve socio-economic and infrastructural resilience. Climate change is also increasingly correlated with more protracted monsoon withdrawal and intense rain events. Taken together, Odisha needs to pivot from anticipating isolated seasonal anomalies to preparing for repeated intense downpours.

It may be tempting to see the recent jerky resumption of negotiations between the Islamic Republic of Iran (IRI) and the United States as *déjà vu*. Similar attempts resulted in the June 17 Memorandum that unravelled within weeks, and the two belligerents resumed their respective blockades of the Strait of Hormuz and Iranian ports.

A different moment now

So, what is different this time? They have both realised that time is not on their side. Their respective domestic considerations make continuation of the seven-month-old war costly and unsustainable. In the short run, going by the past pattern, September 26 saw United States President Trump’s dismissal of Iran’s seven-point proposal, which may be an opening gambit seeking better terms and sequencing. While the Iranian initiative may betray their economic desperation, it also showcases their reasonableness to the Trump sceptics in America and the region who regard his “War of Choice” against Iran as ill-begotten.

The November 3 mid-term congressional elections could upend Mr. Trump as a lame duck. Iranian hardliners, too, need to exhaust this option to justify their aggressiveness. In the longer run, Mr. Trump needs to salvage his legacy to match his extravagant promises. Similarly, the Iranian theocrats need to keep Gen Z engaged and avoid regional blowback from the coagulating mistrust. Thus, while retaining their braggadocio about final victory, each needs to move away from its maximalist obduracy and seek a “Hudna” or temporary peace. The impact of the unfolding imbroglío on the two belligerents as well as on Israel and Gulf states must be examined.

Statistically, the U.S. has a quantitative premium and staying power *vis-à-vis* Iran: It has three times the population, 85 times the GDP and 20 times the military budget. Iran is also at a disadvantage in quality and modernity of weaponry, although its asymmetric strategy has blunted that edge. Washington has weaponised ‘Operation Economic Outcast’ against the already “maximum sanctioned” Iranian economy. Yet, the IRI has not “capitulated”, and the U.S. itself faces inflation, ammunition depletion and isolation. Battle asymmetry aside, their respective combat histories are relevant. The Iran war has been an outlier from the usual U.S. military doctrine of battle dominance through “shock-and-awe”, tech superiority, and leveraging its global primacy through the global politico-financial architecture. The last battle that the U.S. fought as an underdog was its war of independence nearly 250 years ago, and hubris haunts it now. In contrast, Iranians have often been the underdogs to Greeks, Byzantines, Arabs and Ottomans. More recently, British and American manipulation for oil, and Iraq’s 1980 invasion of a fledgling IRI, still frame Iranian



Mahesh Sachdev

Retired Indian Ambassador, specialising in West Asian and oil issues

Both Tehran and Washington must hear the bells toll as mistrust grows and global economies falter

political discourse. Their Shia sect being a minority among the Sunni Muslims reinforces their sense of virtues in suffering and martyrdom. The legacy has made the IRI more determined to face enemies with grit, guile and gumption.

The political ecosystem in Iran is hardened, with dissent stifled and externalised to demonised America and Israel as the two Satans. Mr. Trump has been less successful in getting Americans and the allies abroad behind his trenchant anti-Iran rhetoric. This is partly due to his divisiveness, lack of coherent endgame strategy and inability to protect his allies’ security and economy. Triggering a decapitating war that ignored Iranian politico-military resilience and retaliatory capacity was a strategic blunder. It risked the closure of the two vital maritime choke points, rising hydrocarbon prices, and threatened to push American “hyperpower” into a forever conflict against a middle-ranked, but determined, Iran. Similarly, his recent strategy of inflicting economic pain on Iranians may also fail by making them rally around the flag. Occasional tanker attacks and the ongoing Yemen-Saudi scrimmage notwithstanding, seven months on, the two belligerents are currently licking their wounds.

Uncertain path ahead

Two formidable unknowns loom before some educated projections can be made about the U.S.-Iran conundrum. First, although the Iranian seven-point proposal is based on the June 17 Islamabad memorandum, its precise contents are foggy. Second, the failure of the Islamabad memorandum, subsequent tit-for-tat attacks, the U.S. blockade, Operation Economic Outcast and fire-eating rhetoric since June 17 have deepened mutual mistrust, raising the bar for the *modus vivendi* required for a peace deal. These negatives are balanced by awareness that the continued stalemate would lead to a shared perdition of a hostile Congress blockading Mr. Trump and anti-establishment demonstrations pulling the rug under the Mullahs.

Under a positive scenario, both sides can breathe easier and develop greater mutual empathy. Failure of the June 17 Grand Bargain would have presumably made them more realistic and incremental. So, instead of a race to the bottom, each would need to reluctantly adopt a “Live and Let Live” approach. Despite Mr. Trump’s rejection, signs, such as the Iranian leaders extending their stay in New York, Tehran’s flexibility about controlling the Strait of Hormuz and the use of Qatari mediation instead of alacritous Pakistani generals, seem tentatively positive. To be effective and beneficial to both sides, the deal would have to last at least till November 3, the election date.

Even if this band-aid deal allows the two belligerents to staunch the haemorrhage temporarily, what guarantees its long-term sequel, say, after the Congressional elections? The

Tackling food loss and waste — India’s opportunity

Food loss and waste remain one of the world’s most persistent challenges, with severe consequences for climate, food security, economic costs, and sustainable use of natural resources. India produces enough to feed its population of 1.4 billion, yet a significant share of its produce is lost across the value chain. As the country advances towards more resilient, sustainable and efficient agrifood systems, tackling food loss and waste can deliver a triple win: strengthening food security and nutrition, reducing pressure on natural resources and emissions, and improving incomes and productivity. The International Day of Awareness of Food Loss and Waste, observed annually on September 29, highlights this opportunity for India.

India has already taken the first step by generating nationally representative data.

India’s evidence base, a global first

India is the only country to have conducted three national post-harvest loss surveys. The Ministry of Food Processing Industries assessed losses across 45, 45 and 54 commodities in 2005-07, 2012-14 and 2020-22, respectively, covering the supply chain from farm to retail. The process for a fourth round is now under way.

This sustained effort supports its reporting of the Food Loss Index under the Sustainable Development Goals. However, these estimates cover mainly losses on the farm and in the supply chain. Data on food waste in retail, in hotels and restaurants, and at household level remains far less developed.

The Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations (FAO) is working with the government, research and financial institutions



Konda Reddy Chavva

Officer-in-Charge, FAO Representation in India

Cutting food losses can strengthen food security, conserve resources and advance climate goals

across India’s agrifood systems to translate the triple win from theme to practice. Generating evidence, testing technologies and mobilising investment from farm to market to the city have been the core of these initiatives.

When food is lost, so are the resources used to produce it. Reducing losses can help India meet its climate and resource-efficiency goals while strengthening food security. The scope for reducing losses is greatest with better storage, drying, cooling, moisture management and processing. Digital tools such as traceability systems can further improve how food is moved and managed through the supply chain.

Food loss and waste need to be integrated more systematically into agricultural planning, food-processing strategies, climate action and investment decisions. This means directing finance towards technologies and infrastructure where they can have the greatest impact, while ensuring that solutions remain affordable and accessible to farmers, producer organisations and small businesses. Circular approaches can add another dimension. Surplus food can be redistributed, while unavoidable organic residues can be converted into compost, biogas or energy, reducing waste and creating additional economic value.

Wholesale markets, overlooked opportunity

Assessments by the FAO and the National Council of Agriculture Marketing Boards (COSAMB) have found that major wholesale markets can generate up to 100 tonnes of organic waste a day; in some cities as much as a fifth of all urban organic waste reaches landfills. Nationally, this adds up to an estimated 3.5 million tonnes a year. It is no waste stream but a resource base, which if treated, can

IRI and the U.S. are certain to use the interregnum to “recharge their batteries” and get ready for the next round. Their mutual scepticism and contentious issues such as the nuclear and missile programmes, and the proxy non-state actors could impede any progress towards permanent normalisation. A “high noon” can be expected by mid-November.

The sequel would depend on which of the two belligerents is able to hold his flock together. An inherently unpredictable Mr. Trump may only suspend the gamut of anti-Iran measures and keep his forces deployed in the region. Similarly, Iran is unlikely to let go of control of the Strait of Hormuz as future deterrence. To dissuade him from resuming military kinetics, Iran has already unveiled its possible escalatory ladder that includes advanced weaponry, a possible al-Houthi blockade of Bab al-Mandeb, retaliatory attacks on America’s Gulf allies and hints of pre-emptive strikes. Simultaneously, Tehran has sought a regional diplomatic reset through an interim supervisory arrangement with Oman on the Strait of Hormuz, to be endorsed by other Gulf littoral states.

Wider regional consequences

The past two years have brought Israel and Iran into two direct no-holds-barred wars. Intense drone and missile attacks have convinced Israeli public opinion that Iran constitutes an existential threat. On its part, Iran is unlikely to forgive the Lesser Satan for the assassination of its last Supreme Leader. Their resultant intense regional geopolitical competition, particularly in the Levant, would outlast any Tehran-Washington peace deal, giving their two-millennia-old civilisational animus a new edge. Although the October 27 Knesset elections may see hawkish anti-Iran Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu replaced, any successor is likely to be hostile to an Iran pursuing a nuclear duality. Iran can be expected to rely on its proxies and asymmetric arsenal to create a balance of power with Israel equipped with state-of-the-art U.S. weapons. In the long run, time would favour the one with better innovative skills. While Israel is a “Startup Nation”, Iran has also been impressively inventive under pressure.

Other regional countries in the Arabian Peninsula, Iraq and Jordan, were caught in the crossfire and suffered considerable collateral damage under Iranian retaliation. Their hydrocarbon exports and other economic activities have been stifled. In most cases, their extensive forex reserves are likely to help them tide over the turbulence. However, their long-standing security reliance on the U.S. would call for a thorough reappraisal. Among the uncertainties they need to tackle is the future of oil, now more tightly tied to geopolitics than the supply-demand equilibrium.

In this war, “time” has emerged as an element even more slippery and opaque than oil.

offset roughly 3.3 million tonnes of CO₂-equivalent emissions annually, or close to \$30 million in carbon credits.

A 50-tonne-a-day bio-CNG plant in Surat, Gujarat, has been run through a private-sector partnership for over five years and reportedly cuts methane-related emissions by about 7,500 tonnes a year.

India can adapt such models to local conditions, including the commodity mix and infrastructure of different markets. Municipalities and market committees can also improve organic-waste segregation, collection and treatment, while developing markets for compost, biogas and other recovered materials.

Investment and innovation

India must move from individual interventions to a more connected national approach with financing at its core. The FAO and the Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI) are linking identified food-loss hotspots with climate-resilient technologies such as drying, moisture control, energy-efficient cooling and storage, while SIDBI is arranging finance to help small and medium enterprises adopt them.

The FAO is also working to equip Indian cities with a practical “Package of Practices” for urban food loss and waste management, giving municipalities the tools to measure, prevent, reduce, redistribute and valorise waste across households, wholesale markets, retail and food service.

India now has the data, technology and viable models to reduce food loss and waste. The priority is to close data gaps, direct investment and make loss reduction part of agricultural, food-processing, urban and climate policy.

inequalities. While women are being empowered on the one hand, the continuing crimes against them on the other are deeply disturbing. The judiciary needs to work on a war footing to ensure that cases involving crimes against women are not delayed.

Balasubramaniam Pavani, Secunderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The 80s nostalgia holds caste bias

On July 17, 1985, an argument at a drinking water tank in Karamchedu, in coastal Andhra Pradesh, turned into a massacre. A Madiga woman objected to a Kamma youth soiling the public drinking water tank her family drank from. By nightfall, six Madiga men were dead and three Dalit women had been raped. The police called it a riot. A civil liberties fact-finding team called it a one-sided massacre. The killings birthed the Andhra Pradesh Dalit Mahasabha and a four-decade argument over whether the Constitution reaches inside a village.

Forty-one years later, our feeds are full of the past; AI-generated images of the 80s. Chiffon sarees against sunlit walls, Ambassadors and Contessas. Thus, India became the No. 1 country for Google's Nano Banana image-generation model, and its signature trend was retro-Bollywood portraits. However, where did this aesthetic come from?

Model or mood board, the source material is the same – film stills, magazine spreads, studio portraits, and family albums. However, in the India of the 1980s, all four belonged to households with money and standing; overwhelmingly *savarna*, urban or landed. In 1983, by the Planning Commission's own estimates, 44.5% of Indians, some 323 million people, lived below the poverty line. In 1980, only about a quarter of households lit their homes with electricity. Parliament enacted the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act only in 1989. It is not that Dalit and Adivasi lives were not photographed; they were,



Rejimon Kuttappan
is a workers rights advocate

Tests by MIT Technology Review found that GPT-5 chooses the stereotypical answer in 80 of 105 sentences: the clever man is upper caste, and the sewage cleaner is Dalit

but by others – the state took pictures for its welfare files, activists after an atrocity, as well as anthropologists. The family photograph, which is taken simply to be seen, and is the genre nostalgia runs on, was the one the poor could least afford. Those who could reach a photo studio posed before a painted Swiss chalet; the colony and the forbidden tap remained outside the frame.

A model trained on such an archive reproduces the silence, and hardens it. Tests by MIT Technology Review found that GPT-5 chooses the stereotypical answer in 80 of 105 sentences: the clever man is upper caste, and the sewage cleaner is Dalit. A study presented at the ACM's FAccT conference this year analysed 1,536 images from Gemini's image model, the engine behind Nano Banana, prompted with Indian names and no caste labels. Caste surfaced anyway, through food, neighbourhood, work and worship. One image placed a sanitation worker beneath a banner reading "Bhangi Colony".

Ask the machine for the 1980s and it gives you an upper-caste version. Ask it for a Dalit and it reaches for dirt. The machine did not invent this prejudice; it inherited it and now industrialises it.

A state that looks away
Nobody outside the companies know what is in the training sets. Nor do those who label them (often South Asian workers paid per task to judge which faces look Indian enough). Can a labeller who has never seen a colony flag a model that has never rendered one?

And the government? The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY)'s AI Governance

Guidelines name bias and discrimination as risks, and then leans on voluntary codes and self-certification. The Centre has told the Rajya Sabha that no new horizontal AI law is needed at this stage. Meanwhile, the ₹10,371-crore IndiaAI Mission subsidises "sovereign" models. Moreover, Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw has promised that Indian-trained models will be free of "the bias of many other models". Which bias? Tested how?

A committee is reportedly drafting firmer rules; caste must be written into them. Additionally, the MeitY and the IndiaAI Safety Institute should answer these four questions – what is in the training data? who labelled it? has a caste-bias evaluation been done? will relevant date be published? Anything short of mandatory, public answers is consent by silence.

The counter-evidence is on our screens through films such as *Fandry*, *Kammattipaadam*, *Pariyerum Perumal*, *Vaazhai* etc. What they share is not budget, but authorship. The person remembering has stood on the other side of the water tank. Caste vanishes from nostalgia not because it is subtle but because it is not an object. Caste is who sits where, and who draws from which tap. You cannot buy it as a prop; you will miss it unless it has not shaped your life.

So, do not ban the filter. Go upstream. Ask Dalit, Adivasi, Muslim and working-class families what images they hold from 1975 to 1995, who took them, and what was kept out of frame. Fund community photo archives as seriously as we fund film restoration.

Revisiting the farmer question

India may no longer be an agriculture dominated economy, but it remains deeply dependent on it. While only about 15-18% of GDP now comes from agriculture, the sector continues to employ around 46% of India's workforce. A large part of rural India depends directly on farming and allied activities for its livelihood. This creates an uncomfortable paradox: while India has transformed into an economy driven by industry and services, the economic viability of farming has not kept pace. This is why, as we observe M. S. Swaminathan's death anniversary, the recommendations of the National Commission on Farmers (NCF), which he chaired, need to be revisited.

One of the biggest challenges in Indian agriculture is small landholdings; about 86% of farmers own less than two hectares. Small plots constrain economies of scale, crop diversification and the adoption of new technologies and farming practices. Water is another structural constraint. Around half of all farmed land relies entirely on unpredictable rain, exposing farmers to drought and erratic monsoons. Elsewhere, intensive irrigation has created the opposite problem: groundwater depletion. The Cauvery dispute is ultimately a manifestation of competing demands on a finite resource.

Moreover, climate change is intensifying these vulnerabilities. Erratic rainfall, floods, droughts, and heat waves are increasingly translating into crop losses, while, rising costs of seeds, fertilizers, pesticides, and fuel squeeze farm margins. Farmers often receive only



Priyambada Javakumar
Historian, public speaker, columnist, handloom advocate, and the author of 'The Man Who Fed India'

The challenge is to ensure that greater integration with global markets becomes an opportunity for Indian farmers rather than another source of vulnerability

a miniscule share of the final value of what they produce. Weak storage and processing infrastructure, fragmented supply chains and multiple intermediaries often leave cultivators with little bargaining power.

What the NCF got right
The NCF offered a comprehensive response to many of these problems. Its central insight was that agricultural distress was fundamentally an income and livelihood problem, not merely a productivity problem. Farmer policy, it argued, should be judged by the economic well-being of farmers rather than by increases in production or yield. The Commission, therefore, looked beyond land ownership to timely access to productive resources such as water, credit, technology, livestock, fisheries and other natural resources. It called for closer links between research institutions and cultivators.

Its approach also emphasised ecological sustainability. Higher productivity could not come at the cost of soil health and water security. Efficient water use, sustainable farming practices and conservation of natural resources were integral to agricultural policy.

The NCF also recognised that farmers were at the wrong end of an unequal value chain. It proposed district-level agricultural infrastructure; direct marketing linkages; stronger integration between agriculture and rural industry; and better storage, grading, packaging, processing and transportation. It sought to strengthen farmers' bargaining power. Importantly, the Commission did not assume that everyone

dependent on rural India could or should remain solely dependent on cultivation. It proposed a broader livelihood-security framework encompassing agriculture and allied activities, rural enterprises and non-farm employment.

Over the last two decades, several of NCF's recommendations have been implemented through separate schemes and missions. However, the Commission's larger vision of making farming economically viable, reducing risk, strengthening farmers' bargaining power and integrating production with markets has not been implemented as an integrated framework.

The NCF also anticipated a dilemma that is in sharp focus today: Indian agriculture cannot remain insulated from global markets, but neither can small farmers be exposed to those markets without adequate protection. With India now implementing Free Trade Agreements while also dealing with tariff pressures from the U.S., NCF's ideas have renewed relevance. The challenge is to ensure that greater integration with global markets becomes an opportunity for Indian farmers rather than another source of vulnerability.

The answer is not protectionism, but a combination of remunerative prices, risk management, farmer aggregation, productivity enhancement, value addition, and carefully designed trade safeguards. The task today is not to mechanically reproduce the recommendations, but to update and complete their underlying vision for the agriculture sector.

Gender disparities in contraceptive use and sterilisation

In contrast to 36.5% women reporting sterilisation, only a meagre 0.5% men reported male sterilisation in NFHS-6

DATA POINT

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
Nitika Francis

The World Health Organization (WHO) has issued new guidelines on expanding contraceptive options and, for the first time, set out the benchmarks for a new generation of reversible male contraceptives that could give men more alternatives.

The timing of the announcement is significant for India. After focussing on family-planning policies for decades, fertility has fallen below the replacement level (**Chart 1**). Figures from the latest National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6) for 2023-24, show a decline in the share of married women who have an unmet need for family planning by one percentage point from NFHS-5 for 2019-21.

Yet, the NFHS-6 also shows that the demographic achievement has not altered the gender imbalance in contraceptive responsibility, with both temporary and permanent contraception measures increasingly used/taken by women.

Chart 2 shows an increase in the proportion of currently married women aged 15-49 using any contraceptive method, from 66.7% as per the NFHS-5 (for 2019-21) to 69.1% in 2023-24. Though majority of these women used modern methods of contraception, their use has fallen from 56.4% to 52.7%, while traditional methods – principally rhythm/fertility-awareness and withdrawal – have risen sharply by 6 percentage points between NFHS-5 and NFHS-6, which is the largest increase in the reported use of any contraceptive method between the two surveys.

While the NFHS data do not establish the reason for this increase, possible factors include concerns about side-effects, convenience, privacy, partner preferences, access and a desire to avoid hormonal or invasive methods, with women being the principal users of

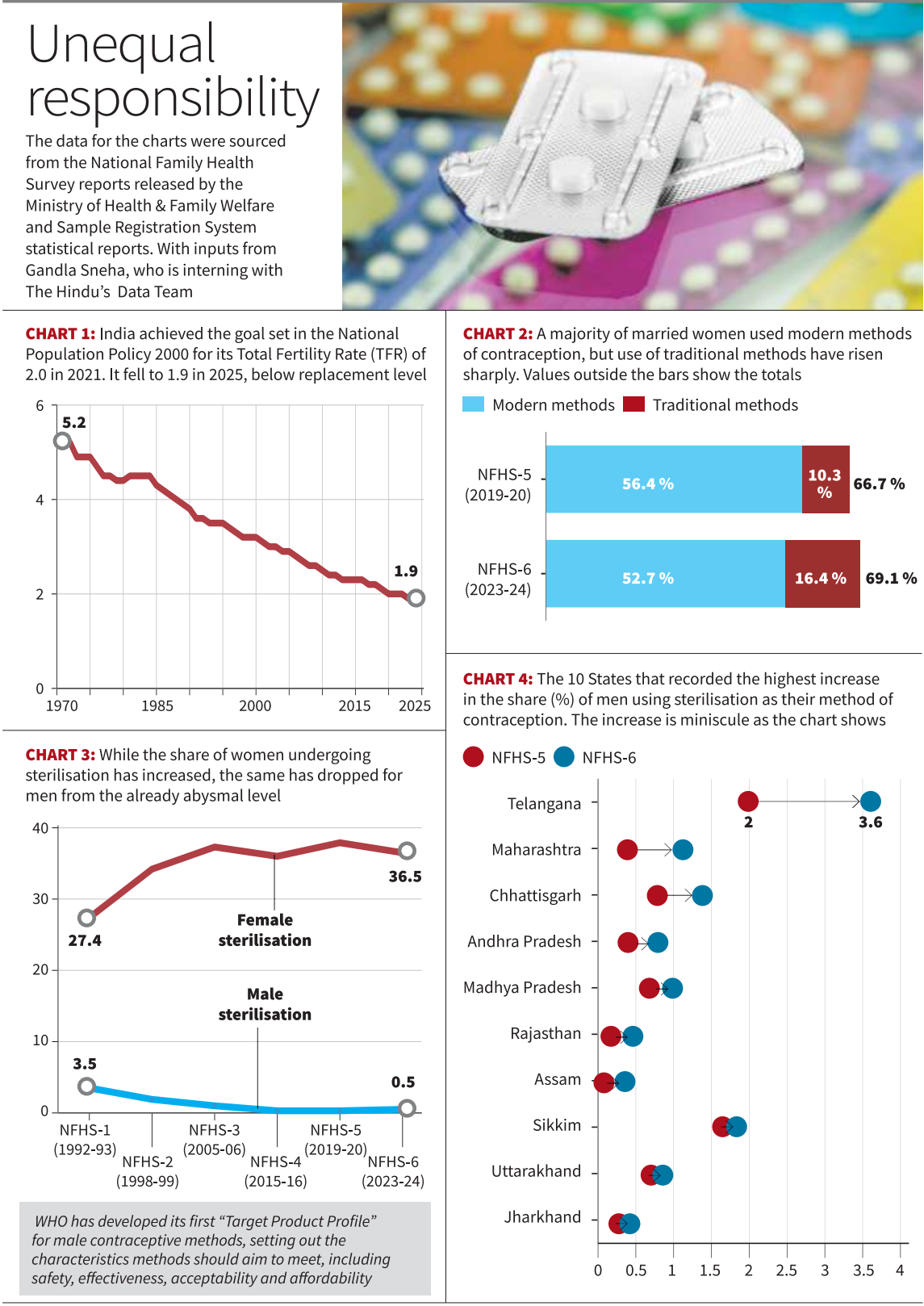
such methods.

The decline in the use of modern methods is reflected in female sterilisation as well. Women who are married and reporting female sterilisation came down marginally from 37.9% in NFHS-5 to 36.5% in NFHS-6. Importantly, sterilisation also remains overwhelmingly female. In contrast to 36.5% reporting female sterilisation, only a meagre 0.5% men reported male sterilisation in NFHS-6 – a miniscule increase from 0.3% in NFHS-5. The disparity becomes more striking when the data is viewed over three decades (**Chart 3**). Female sterilisation climbed rapidly between NFHS-1 and NFHS-3 and has remained at around 36-38%; male sterilisation fell from 3.4% in NFHS-1 to 0.5% in NFHS-6.

A look at State-wise figures on male sterilisation shows that even the States that achieved low Total Fertility Rate (TFR) early were not exceptions to this trend. The share of men who used sterilisation as their preferred contraceptive method increased between NFHS-5 and NFHS-6 in 22 States. And yet, none of these States, barring Telangana, saw an increase of more than one percentage point, as shown in **Chart 4**. Numbers indicate that as India moved towards replacement-level fertility, vasectomy or male sterilisation went from a visible component of family planning to a marginal one.

While the sterilisation process for females is not inherently unsafe, the physical intervention required to end fertility is less invasive for men and can be performed under local anaesthesia.

"Choice is a gender equality issue," said Pascale Allotey, Director of WHO's Department of Sexual, Reproductive, Maternal, Child and Adolescent Health and Ageing, while releasing the new guidelines. WHO said its own research has challenged a longstanding assumption that men would not use new contraceptives. India should leverage the new WHO guidelines to address the gender imbalance.



FROM THE ARCHIVES



FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 29, 1976

Shukla's tribute to Bharathi

Madras, September 28: The State Government has decided to acquire the house at Triplicane in Madras where the Tamil poet Subrahmanya Bharathi lived during his last days and also to rename Pycrofts Road as Bharathi Salai.

This was announced to-day by the Governor, Mr. Mohanlal Sukhadia, while inaugurating a month-long Son et Lumiere programme on Bharathi at a function presided over by the Minister for Information and Broadcasting, Mr. V.C. Shukla.

The sound and light spectacle entitled "Oru Sakthi Pirakuthu Mochinile" in the courtyard of Rajaji Hall portrays different facets of the poet as a nationalist, journalist, social reformed and devotee. Mr. Shukla said that though the programme was to run for a month, if the response was encouraging, it would not only be prolonged but extended to other parts.

Tamil Nadu had every reason to be proud of Bharathi and the part played by him during the freedom struggle was written in letters of gold. The Governor said that though the poet had lived only for 39 years he has bequeathed to the people a priceless treasure of patriotic poetry which had immortalised him. His patriotic fervour was so great that he poured out his heart in soul-stirring poems. His songs were even-to-day in the lips of young and old of Tamil Nadu and elsewhere. Mr. Sukhadia said that efforts were now being made by the UNESCO to publish a translation of some of Bharathi's important poems.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 29, 1926

Supply of safety razors to British Army

London, September 27: The decision of the War Office to serve out safety razors to soldiers instead of open blades, was raised in Parliament in connection with a contract for the supply of the former made by a company bearing a well-known American name.

Captain King, for the Government, explained that the company with which the arrangement was made was the offshoot of an entirely British character. He mentioned that one condition of the contract was that the Company should take over the War Officer stocks of over hundred thousand long-handled razors in exchange for safety razors.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount earned by MCD from unipole advertisement in 2026

79 in ₹ crore. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has no records of estimated revenue losses from unallotted or inactive unipole advertising sites across its 12 zones, or of action taken against officials for alleged negligence in tendering or revenue oversight, according to an official response. The civic body has identified 1,235 unipole sites across its 12 zones. PTI

Crimes against women reported in Odisha since June 2024

71,769 As many as 71,769 cases of crimes against women were registered at police stations across Odisha between June 2024 and July 2026, Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi informed the Assembly on Monday. Similarly, 21,069 cases involving crimes against women were registered till the end of July, he said. PTI

Children in India who lack sanitation services in schools

50 in million. Nearly a fifth of the children with no access to sanitation services in schools are in India, the highest for any country in the world, according to the WHO-UNICEF Joint Monitoring Programme (JMP) report. India has 50 million of the world's 244 million children who did not have sanitation services in schools in 2025, the report noted. PTI

Percentage increase in India's industrial output in August

8 in per cent. India's industrial output increased by 8 per cent in August from 7.4 per cent in the preceding month, mainly due to a good show by the manufacturing sector, according to the latest government data released on Monday. The data showed that the mining and quarrying sector contracted by 5.6 per cent in August against 15.8 per cent growth a year ago. PTI

Mobile numbers blocked in Rajasthan due to CSEAM

15,326 The Rajasthan Police have blocked 15,326 mobile numbers, nearly 7,800 URLs and profiles and 100 devices allegedly linked to online circulation of child sexual exploitation and abuse material (CSEAM), a senior official said on Monday. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us facebook.com/thehindu X.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

A new governance model for Ladakh

Ladakh was made a Union Territory under the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act, 2019, prompting concerns from local groups about preservation of Ladakh's culture and demands for Sixth Schedule status; the Centre has proposed to insert Article 371-K into the Constitution to provide for a directly elected legislative body instead

EXPLAINER

C.B.P. Srivastava

The demand by Ladakh for Sixth Schedule status and the proposal made by the Ministry of Home Affairs to provide for a directly elected legislative body for governance in the Union Territory has created a paradoxical situation and raised the question of whether a UT can be granted such status. Whether it would be constitutionally valid to equate States and UTs in the context of their respective governance is a question worth examining. Indian federalism is unique in the sense that, in general, it functions as a federation, while during an Emergency, it becomes perfectly a union. This is why the Supreme Court has called it “Amphibian” in *State of Rajasthan v. Union of India* (1977). This observation signifies that while India intends to distribute the resources equitably through its federal structure, it retains a unitary character to ensure the unity and integrity of the nation.

Moreover, India's territory includes States, UTs and any other territory acquired under international law, making it a decentralised federal design. The political idea behind this design is to include every cultural and ethnic group in democratic governance to sustain its political structure. This has also been the primary reason for the provisions of the Fifth and Sixth Schedules, which provide for Scheduled Areas and Autonomous Districts, especially to ensure the inclusion of tribal communities. From a functional perspective, this design is founded on the ‘Doctrine of Proportionality’, so that the Rawlsian principle of justice, i.e., the greatest advantage to the least advantaged could be achieved. Considering its unique ethnic composition and cultural specificity, Ladakh has demanded Sixth Schedule status. However, the Central Government is unwilling to provide this



A protest demanding Sixth Schedule status for Ladakh, held in Leh in January 2026. ANI

status and has instead proposed an elected legislative authority for a sui generis model of governance.

What is the Sixth Schedule?

The Sixth Schedule covers only Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura and Mizoram primarily because most of these areas were part of Assam during British rule and were classified as “Excluded” or “Partially Excluded” areas. Meghalaya, Tripura, and Mizoram later became separate States, retaining their Sixth Schedule protections. The Sixth Schedule is governed by Article 244(2) and 275(1). The Governor has the power to create new Autonomous Districts through a public notification. Each such district is governed by a district council with a maximum of 30 members. In short, the States covered by the Sixth Schedule enjoy considerable autonomy in governance.

Ladakh was made a Union Territory without a Legislative Assembly under the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act,

2019. Many local groups expressed concerns about protecting the culture of Ladakh's people, including their language, traditions and customary practices. They also wanted to prevent outsiders from acquiring land in Ladakh, as it could deprive local people of their land rights. Above all, local groups are dissatisfied with the way political representation has been given to Ladakh. All these factors have contributed significantly to the demand for Sixth Schedule status.

Proposal of Article 371-K

The Government has proposed to insert Article 371-K in Part XXI of the Constitution (Temporary, Transitional and Special Provisions) to strike a balance between national administration and local self-government. If the Government grants special status under the Sixth Schedule to Ladakh, the autonomy it would receive might prove detrimental to national security, given Ladakh's strategic location in the vicinity of China. However,

the ethno-cultural aspects of Ladakh must also be protected through an efficient and autonomous local government.

Against this backdrop, the proposal to provide a directly elected legislative authority appears more rational, as it would not only ensure adequate and proper political representation but also involve the local population in the decision-making process. The proposed structure may place this body above the existing Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils (LAHDCs), while retaining panchayats and district-level institutions. However, the role of the Lieutenant Governor after the constitution of this authority is yet to be clearly defined. Further, the extent of powers that the said authority might enjoy, particularly in terms of financial autonomy, remains to be seen. As India is a functional federation in which financial and residuary powers are vested in the Union rather than the States, it remains to be decided whether the legislative authority would enjoy any such powers.

Constitutionality of the proposal

Granting special status or providing a sui generis model of governance to a Union Territory is certainly constitutionally valid, as India's constitutional governance practices equitable distribution of rights among States and other units within its territory. It also practises the principle of proportionality and may, therefore, provide special powers or status to a UT based on its location, developmental requirements and the need to protect its democratic identity. Earlier, through constitutional amendments, Parliament has made special provisions for the National Capital Territory of Delhi under Articles 239 AA and 239 AB. This makes it clear that Parliament may grant special status to any UT.

Thus, the proposal to insert Article 371-K is expected to provide the required autonomy without adversely affecting the territorial integrity of the nation. (C.B.P. Srivastava is president, Centre for Applied Research in Governance, Delhi)

THE GIST

The Sixth Schedule, which is governed by Article 244(2) and 275(1) provides for the creation of Autonomous Districts. It covers Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura and Mizoram

The Government has proposed to insert Article 371-K in Part XXI of the Constitution (Temporary, Transitional and Special Provisions) to strike a balance between national administration and local self-government

What does Centre's decision on NEET-SS seats entail?

Why did the Central government agree to reduce the qualifying percentile for NEET-SS?

Nivedita S.

The story so far:

In September 17, 2026, the Union government agreed to the Supreme Court's suggestion of reducing the qualifying percentile for the 2025 National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test-Super Speciality (NEET-SS) from 50% to 30%. Following this, the Medical Counselling Committee (MCC) commenced a stray round from September 25 to fill the remaining 1,857 vacant seats. The Centre also agreed to give the 40 vacant in-service seats in Tamil Nadu back to the State.

What is the NEET-SS examination?

The NEET-SS is the only entrance examination for admission to DM (Doctorate of Medicine), MCh (Master of Chirurgery), and DrNB (Doctorate of National Board) super-speciality courses

in India. It is conducted by the National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS), an autonomous body under the Union Health Ministry. There are over 7,000 seats in the country, with around 15,000 applicants every year.

NEET-SS is not a single unified examination. The courses offered under it are divided into 15 groups: general medicine, general surgery, orthopaedics, paediatrics, obstetrics and gynaecology, anesthesiology, radiology, respiratory medicine, microbiology, pathology, psychiatry, pharmacology, ENT, critical care, and medical oncology. Each group covers multiple specialty subjects. For example, general medicine covers cardiology, nephrology, neurology, and seven other subjects. Each group has a different question paper and the cut-off for each paper varies.

Why were seats going vacant?

Super-specialisation provides advanced

clinical training and teaching for doctors.

In India, it is in high demand in private corporate hospitals. “The market factor plays a big role. Doctors are taking super-speciality seats which give more chances for better practice and more money. If the seats they prefer are not available for their ranks this year, they will try the next time. This is a major reason why seats are going unfilled,” said Dr. Ravindranath, general secretary of Doctors' Association for Social Equality.

Cardiology, neurosurgery, medical oncology, and gastroenterology are among those subjects which are highly competitive with lower vacancies. Seats mostly go vacant in those courses which do not have as much demand. For example, cardiovascular and thoracic surgery has witnessed a drop in demand as medical treatment now relies on drugs and radioactive interventions over surgery. Super-specialisation in paediatric surgery has a lower demand due to

competition from doctors in other specialisations.

In 2023, after 1,003 seats remained vacant, a Supreme Court Bench led by Justices B.R. Gavai and Vikram Nath asked the Centre to find a solution. The Bench called these vacant seats a “wastage of resources”. Following this, the Medical Counselling Committee (MCC) announced that the 2023 candidates with zero percentile were also eligible to secure a seat if they opt for it; however, many seats still remained vacant. In 2024, around 600 NEET-SS seats were vacant after two rounds of counselling, which led to mop-up rounds after court intervention.

What did doctors from T.N. demand?

In 2026, while hearing the case filed by Tamil Nadu Medical Officers Association, the court said the large number of vacancies in the 2025 NEET-SS admissions made the case for reduction of the qualifying percentile “compelling.” The Bench of Justices B.V. Nagarathna and Joymalya Bagchi said access to super-speciality for in-service government doctors must become easier as they are appearing for the exam while providing service to the public at the same time.

Under G.O. Ms. No. 462, Tamil Nadu has reserved 50% of NEET-SS seats for in-service doctors in State medical colleges. This quota was upheld by the Supreme Court in 2022. In the 2025 cycle, the State had

reserved 219 seats for in-service doctors, of which only 68 were filled. Over 111 candidates remained on the waiting list. In the petition, the Tamil Nadu Medical Officers Association challenged the “premature diversion” of 152 seats reserved for in-service doctors working in State hospitals into the All-India Quota. Senior advocate P. Wilson, for the petitioner, said that many candidates, particularly from rural parts of the State, were awaiting a reduction in the qualifying percentile. This is relevant as there is no caste- or religion-based reservation in this exam. He also sought protection of the in-service quota. This led to the Centre giving 40 vacant seats back to the State.

Is this adequate to address the issue?

“Reducing the cut-off might address this problem to an extent, but it cannot prevent seats from going vacant,” Dr. Ravindranath said. He added that the low number of seats in government hospitals in States like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, and the northeast is worsening the issue. Along with this, employment and promotion opportunities have not increased for super-specialists. This is because in government hospitals, new departments for such specialisations have not been established. The low stipends and heavy workload in the course are also factors that discourage candidates from pursuing super-specialisation.

Nepal’s flash foods: How can communities rebuild after a disaster?

The state is often quick to respond to disasters, but its approach is usually centralised and top-down, often undermining the role of local bodies, which have greater knowledge of the local context; these bodies need to have a say in issues such as the resettlement of communities

INTERVIEW

Nimesh Dhungana

Kunal Shankar
Nivedita Varadarajan

In August 26, floods hit Nepal’s Rasuwa, Nuwakot and Dhading districts, wiping away entire towns and communities. Roads and bridges were washed away, and telecommunications networks were down. The immediate focus was on rescuing people trapped under debris and providing relief to those affected. A month on, the focus has now shifted to rehabilitation, rebuilding and long-term recovery.

The Hindu spoke to Dr. Nimesh Dhungana, Senior Lecturer in Disaster Studies and Global Health at the University of Manchester’s Humanitarian and Conflict Response Institute (HCRI), who studies disasters through the lens of governance, democracy and accountability, about recovery after the devastating flash floods. Dr. Dhungana describes himself as an accidental disaster researcher who started studying disasters after the 2015 Nepal earthquake. He also studied the Himalayan country’s response to the COVID pandemic. Edited excerpts:

Is there a difference between the way the government responded to the 2015 earthquake, the COVID pandemic and the recent flash floods? The government has a sense of moral responsibility [to save lives] when a disaster of this scale strikes. One common element is that the state acts decisively and with the speed required in the aftermath of such disasters. It mobilises its emergency forces, led by the security forces. However, we are increasingly seeing that the state’s response is not matched by a sustained commitment to long-term recovery and reconstruction. That responsibility starts to fade, particularly when it comes to listening to affected communities and ensuring that their rights are protected. It is about transparency, engagement with the affected population and ensuring that they have a say in the recovery and reconstruction process.

Your work suggests that disasters expose government failures that have built up, or existed long before the disaster itself. What do you mean by this?

I think there is a long-standing debate about what constitutes a disaster. The recent floods have also forced us to revisit this basic question: what is a disaster in the first place? One way of thinking about it is as an event that is often unpredictable and attracts considerable attention from national and international media, as the recent floods did.

Another way of thinking about a disaster is as a process. It is something that happens because of long-term vulnerabilities. Disasters are not caused by nature alone. I think there is a growing consensus that a disaster is more of a process than just an event. Unfortunately, it is more comfortable to think of a disaster as an event, something beyond our control. We saw that with the 2015 earthquake and the pandemic. This is not



Trail of destruction: Damaged houses covered in sludge in the aftermath of the flash flood in Nepal’s Rasuwa district. AFP

limited to Nepal; it is a wider issue. I think this is a problematic way of looking at disasters. It can absolve state actors of accountability. We need deeper introspection into the choices we make, our governance structures and institutions. We should adopt a more rights-based approach to disaster response and rethink how we address longstanding inequalities and injustices.

The state is often quick to respond to disasters, but its approach is usually centralised and top-down. This undermines the roles and responsibilities of local bodies, which are the frontline responders.

How do you balance the role of the local bodies and the federal government, especially when a massive disaster strikes a region, leaving the local communities wiped out?

It depends on the scale of the disaster. The flash floods in Nepal are unprecedented. Given the scale of the disaster, Nepal needs support from outside, not just nationally, but also internationally. However, this is no excuse for not involving local representatives in the process. Ward officials, elected representatives, local NGOs and community-based organisations, which are often at the forefront of disaster response, have greater knowledge of the local context. In the Rasuwa floods, questions have been raised about their role being undermined by the centralised disaster response.

Mobilising military and security forces for disaster relief is a way of centralisation. We need to think beyond security forces for the immediate response and recovery. We need to engage more civilian actors for immediate relief and in policy-making. We should empower the local government with resources, equipment and infrastructure

to deal with disasters. In the longer term, policy-wise, local bodies need to have a say in answering the big questions, like how we resettle communities.

The problem is that, in Nepal and elsewhere, reconstruction tends to focus more on physical reconstruction, like building houses and other infrastructure. But they are often not aligned with community priorities. It also raises a deeper question: what does recovery mean? What if people don’t want to move from a certain place? How do we listen to their claims and choices? The local government can play a really important role here.

Your work says there is a difference between the community ‘having a voice’ and ‘having teeth’. What does that mean?

This also stems from a more rights-based approach to thinking about development and disasters. There’s a long-standing literature on the role of voice in this kind of difficult situation, going back to Amartya Sen’s work in famine prevention. He did seminal work on how we should think about famine not just as a problem of food production, but also in terms of entitlement failures and whether communities have the right to demand answers from authorities.

Be it the 2015 earthquake or the recent Rasuwa floods, bereaved families have demanded answers from the State about the way rescue and relief operations have been organised. There have also been questions about fairness and transparency in relief distribution. This is also about democracy and the responsiveness of State institutions, and whether they listen to these demands. ‘Teeth’ also means having the resources and ability to respond through concrete policy and programmatic interventions.

The idea of ‘voice’ and ‘teeth’, comes from scholar Jonathan Fox’s work. I have

drawn on that idea, but also looked at it in the context of disaster. Jonathan Fox talks about how ‘voice’ and ‘teeth’ come together to operate as a ‘bite’. The ‘bite’, in this sense, is concrete measures that would protect the rights and welfare of disaster-affected communities.

What should a genuinely good, decentralised, community-led approach to disaster governance look like?

At the ward level, disaster management governance committees exist, but only on paper. We need human and financial resources to respond, as well as physical resources such as ambulances, hospitals and relief shelters. Emergency operations are not just about having resources; it is also about the general logic of governance. Disasters are better managed locally, as local governments have knowledge of the local context.

How do we ensure that human decisions do not make disasters even worse?

This comes back to who has the power to make decisions. The major casualties of the recent Nepal floods were hydropower and the road networks. Some estimates say that almost 10% of Nepal’s hydropower infrastructure was wiped out. Who granted licenses to construct hydropower projects in these areas? This is fundamentally a question of governance. Decisions about building critical infrastructure, such as schools and hospitals, on riverbanks are linked to human choices.

Do communities that are victims of infrastructural breakdowns have any say? What role did they have in the making of these infrastructures?

It is important to have a conversation about the climate crisis, but we also need to examine what happened downstream. What was the government’s role before the disaster? Did it do enough to protect the public? That is where a rights-based, more governance-centric approach to disasters comes in. It also involves a more social scientific approach to understanding disasters, rather than looking at them solely from the perspective of hazards and physical sciences.

How do we plan in such a way as to either avoid a disaster or rebuild after one?

There is no single cause of disaster. Some scholars have long called disasters as a wicked problem because they result from a combination of factors, such as natural hazards, risks and vulnerabilities. In the context of climate change, the recent floods in Nepal have made it painfully clear that this issue will become even more important. We need to be thinking about disasters from a multidimensional, interdisciplinary perspective. We have seen many disasters along the Nepal-India border that defy national boundaries.

We also need to take a transboundary approach.

How do we bring this conversation into policymaking? How do we decentralise disaster governance in a way that gives more power and resources to local bodies? We need accountability and responsibility. The government must listen to communities affected by disasters.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the origin and meaning of the expression “cock and bull story”? (K. Balaji, Chennai)

When you say that someone gave you a “cock and bull story”, what you are implying is that the individual told you a story that was unbelievable; he told you a story that was obviously a lie. People often resort to cock and bull stories when they want to come up with an excuse for not having done something. Here are a few examples.

When I asked Namrata why she hadn’t done her assignment, she gave me some cock and bull story about being abducted by aliens.

When the Chairman asked for an explanation, all he got from the Vice President was some cock and bull story.

There are several explanations as to the origin of this expression. Some scholars believe that the idiom has its origins in the fables that we all read as children; stories in which animals behave and talk like human beings. Such stories are often considered to be unrealistic by people who are very practical in their outlook. They can’t believe that animals like lions, bulls, foxes, etc. can actually talk. Hence the expression “cock and bull story”.

What is the difference between lacto-vegetarian and lacto-ovo-vegetarian? (S. Amarnath, Mysore)

A “lacto-vegetarian” is someone who not only eats vegetables but also dairy products like milk, cheese, butter, etc. He doesn’t eat eggs and products made from eggs. A lacto-ovo-vegetarian, on the other hand, is someone who takes both milk and egg products. By the way, a person who eats only vegetables is called a “vegan”.

Which of the following sentences is correct? “Each of the children were given chocolates” or “Each of the children was given chocolates”. (K. Gauri, Tirupati)

In such sentences, according to the rules of English grammar “each” should be followed by a singular verb. Therefore your second sentence will meet the approval of a grammarian. Here are a few examples.

Each of the books was gift wrapped carefully.

Each of the teachers wants to donate a hundred rupees.

Nowadays, there is a tendency to use a plural verb instead of the singular one in such constructions. This is especially true in speech. Here are a few examples.

Each of his plays have been hits.

Each of his ideas are clearly stated.

What is the difference between “stairway” and “staircase”? (D.S. Bhat, Bangalore)

Most people tend to use the two words interchangeably. For the common man, steps which allow him to move from one floor to another can be called either a staircase or a stairway. There is no difference between the two.

But I understand there are certain technical differences. And one of them is that a staircase usually has a handrail, while a stairway needn’t always have one. Published in *The Hindu* on February 12, 2002

Word of the day

Bemusement:
confusion resulting from failure to understand

Synonyms: puzzlement, befuddlement

Usage: He shook his head in bemusement at the child’s unusual question.

Pronunciation:
newsth.live/bemusement

International Phonetic Alphabet: /bəˈmjuːzmənt/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

THE DAILY QUIZ

On this day 72 years ago, CERN’s founding convention entered into force. A quiz on the storied science lab

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1
Since 2012, CERN has held ‘observer status’ at the X, allowing it to attend sessions and participate in the work of the organisation, but without having the right to vote. As a result, CERN has been able to contribute scientific and technical expertise central to X’s work. Name X.

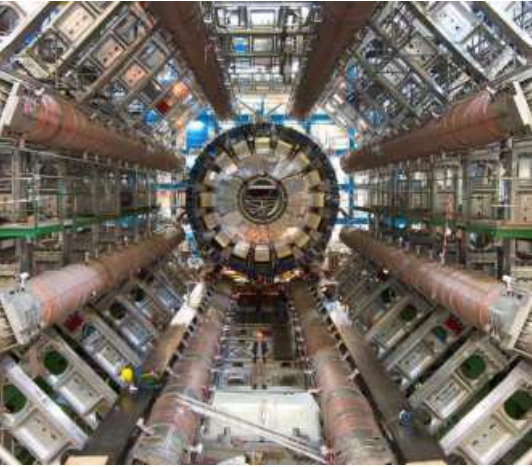
QUESTION 2
When he was working at CERN, the English scientist _____ invented the World Wide Web. By 1990, he had created the first web browser, server, and website plus core technologies like HTML, HTTP, and URLs. Fill in the blanks.

QUESTION 3
What did India’s Department of Atomic Energy present to CERN in 2004? It was

selected to commemorate the Indian government’s association with the organisation.

QUESTION 4
Of the 12 founding members of CERN, 11 remain. Name the country that ceded its membership in 1961. Its government said the country’s high-energy physics programme was too limited to benefit substantially from CERN.

QUESTION 5
CERN runs a distributed computing project called _____. Here, people can donate spare processing power on their personal computers over the internet, which a bespoke network makes use of to help perform calculations required by the Large Hadron Collider experiments.



Visual question: Name this instrument, which is the largest particle collider on the Large Hadron Collider at CERN. It is 46 m long, 25 m high and 25 m wide, and weighs around 7,000 tonnes. MAXIMILIEN BRICE/CERN

Questions and answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. Her birth name. **Ans: Hema**
2. Significance of the song *Paa Lagoon Kar Jori*. **Ans: It was her first recorded Hindi solo**
3. The music director who backed her, after she was rejected for a having a ‘thin voice’. **Ans: Ghulam Haider**
4. Common element to the songs: *Beeti Na Bitai Raina*, *Rootho Rootho Piya* and *Yaara Seeli Seeli (Lekin)*? **Ans: She won the National Awards for these songs**
5. She composed music for Marathi films in the 1960s under this name. **Ans: Anandghan**
6. The rendition that brought PM Jawaharlal Nehru to tears in 1963. **Ans: Aye Mere Watan Ke Logon**
7. The music for the thumri *Kanha Main Tose Hari* was composed by this director. **Ans: Satyajit Ray**
8. She was awarded the Bharat Ratna in this year. **Ans: 2001**
Visual: The location of this installation. **Ans: Ayodhya**
Early birds: Piyali Tuli| Erfanally Oosmany| Prem Nath Tiwari| Sukdev Shet| Gursharan Lal Vadhera
Correction: The quoted song in question 7 of the quiz was not sung by Lata Mangeshkar.

INBRIEF



UAE signals another \$25 bn investment in India: Goyal

The UAE has indicated its intent to invest an additional \$25 billion in India in the near future, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday, as the two countries agreed to deepen cooperation across ports, shipbuilding, energy security, space technology and financial services. Speaking after co-chairing the 14th India-UAE High-Level Joint Task Force on Investments with Abu Dhabi Investment Authority MD Sheikh Hamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Mr. Goyal said the UAE has already invested around \$25 billion in India and has a longer-term objective of taking its investments in the country to \$100 billion. The discussions at the task force meeting covered investments, trade facilitation, taxation, logistics, energy, market access and financial cooperation, including use of local currency for bilateral trade.

NMDC commissions 2 MTPA pellet plant in Nagarnar

NMDC has commissioned a 2 million tonne per annum pellet plant in Nagarnar, Chhattisgarh, as part of a ₹5,427-crore integrated iron ore processing, pipeline and pellet making project connecting its iron ore operations in Bacheli with the company’s steel plant in Nagarnar. The project includes a new iron ore processing plant in Bacheli, a 15 MTPA slurry pipeline besides the 2 MTPA pellet plant. The 135 km slurry pipeline carries processed iron ore concentrate from Bacheli to Nagarnar, providing an alternative to transporting the material by road, the company said on Sunday. The slurry pipeline passes through 61 villages in Bastar and Dantewada districts and is designed to reduce the movement of processed ore by road, provide alternate mode of evacuation and lower dependency on railways and ensures a dedicated link between Bacheli operations and Nagarnar, NMDC said.

Tewolde’s flight plan: cost saving, deeper AI–AI Express synergies

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI



Tewolde Gebremariam

Cost cutting and deeper integration between Air India (AI) and low-cost arm Air India Express (AI Express) will be at the centre of CEO-designate Tewolde Gebremariam’s agenda, with the new AI chief calling for shared services, greater asset utilisation and organisation-wide focus on cutting duplication and improving efficiency. In his first town hall with staff, Mr. Gebremariam said AI and AI Express should operate as ‘multiple brands with a single unit of production,’ with the two airlines retaining distinct customer-facing identities while sharing resources wherever possible, sources said.

While AI will continue as a full-service carrier and AI Express as low-cost carrier, he said customer-facing functions would remain distinct while areas such as IT, HRD, finance and engineering could be streamlined and shared. “The objective would be to reduce costs and strengthen the airlines’ competitiveness,” he said.

Whether the two airlines ultimately operate with one Air Operator Certificate (AOC) or retain two was “secondary” to achieving operational synergies. “Cost saving is top on the agenda,” he said, urging staff to identify and propose cost-saving opportunities and help build a stronger culture of cost consciousness.

“No burning cash” He also linked cost agenda with the wider financial challenge, saying, “We cannot continue to lose money. We cannot continue to burn cash.” On revenue, he called for an urgent improvement in revenue/available seat

kilometre (RASK) and greater use of cargo as a revenue stream, saying AI was losing to foreign freighters. Safety and reliability, meanwhile, stay core priorities, with Mr. Gebremariam calling for consistent operational performance, including clean and safe aircraft, on-time departures and arrivals, baggage travelling with passengers and better disruption recovery. He also described growth as ‘the oxygen of business’ while stressing it must be profitable and sustainable. The CEO further called for a “One Air India” approach, a leaner and flatter organisation, fewer silos and reviews of outsourcing, IT systems and internal processes.

SEBI clears Vinod Adani of charges in shareholding case

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI



SEBI said the role played by Vinod Adani was advisory.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) cleared Vinod Adani, elder brother of Adani Group chairman Gautam Adani, of allegations relating to the violation of minimum public shareholding (MPS) norms and Prohibition of Fraudulent and Unfair Trade Practices (PFUTP) regulations. In its final order, SEBI said the “foundational allegations” of effective control by Vinod Adani over two foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) and Opal Investment Pvt. Ltd. were not established. Consequently, the regulator did not uphold the allegation the

MPS norms of listed Adani Group firms were violated. The case involved allegations against 30 noticees, including individuals, foreign investment funds and Adani Group entities. The primary charge was Mr. Vinod Adani exercised control over investments made by two FPIs –

Excel Investment and Global Opportunities Management Ltd (GMAML) – in three Adani Group firms: Adani Enterprises, Adani Power and Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone. The allegation was this investment was in violation of SEBI regulations, which do not allow promoters to hold more than 25% in listed entities. Rejecting the charge, SEBI said the role played by Vinod Adani in relation to the two FPIs was advisory in nature and based on non-binding pacts. Separately, SEBI settled alleged MPS violations involving 18 noticees named in the order. The settlement included Adani Group chairman Gautam Adani.

India has over 80 days of fuel reserve, says Minister Puri

Saptaparno Ghosh
KOLKATA

India has more than 80 days of fuel reserves, said Hardeep Singh Puri, Union Petroleum Minister at an event here. “The number of refineries has grown, import terminals have grown and I am sometimes asked why isn’t the country’s SPR bigger?” he stated, adding, “Please combine everything, we have more than eighty plus days [worth] of capacity to store,” the Minister added. (The reporter is in Kolkata at the invitation of the Union Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas)

Rupee breaches 96 mark second time within 2 weeks, settles 22 paise lower

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI



The rupee opened on a negative note at 95.89 and hit the intraday low of 96.05

The rupee breached the 96 level for the second time in two weeks before settling 22 paise lower at 95.97 against the U.S. dollar on Monday, amid risk-off sentiment in global markets after the U.S. rejected Iran’s proposal, diminishing hopes of a truce in West Asia. Forex traders said the global risk sentiment deteriorated as the stalemate between the U.S. and Iran continued, leading to a surge in crude oil prices and massive withdrawal of foreign funds from domestic equity markets, weighing on the Indian currency. At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened on a negative

dollar. The rupee breached the crucial 96 level for the second time since September 17, when it slid to 96.10 to a dollar during intraday after a 25 basis point rate hike by the U.S. Federal Reserve. “The Indian rupee declined by nearly 20 paise on risk-off sentiments in global markets after the US rejected a deal proposal by Iran, diminishing hopes of reopening the Strait of Hormuz. Brent crude oil breached the \$108 per barrel mark while global equities tanked. US dollar and US Treasury yields also strengthened,” said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset Sharekhan. Mr. Choudhary further added that the rupee is expected to trade with a negative bias as global risk sentiments deteriorated with the continued stalemate between the U.S. and Iran. “Falling risk assets and surge in crude oil prices may continue to pressurise the rupee. However, any intervention by the RBI may support the rupee at lower levels,” Mr. Choudhary said, adding that traders may take cues from speeches by various FOMC members. Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, traded at 101.12, up 0.16%. Brent crude futures, the global oil benchmark, were trading higher by 3.57% at \$108.04 per barrel in futures trade.

Lupin gets U.S. FDA nod for Apixaban Oral Suspension

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Lupin has received tentative approval from the U.S. Food and Drug Administration for its new drug application for Apixaban Oral Suspension 1.25mg/mL. The approval was obtained through the 505(b) (2), new drug approval, pathway of the regulator. Upon final approval, the product will be manufactured at its Somerset, New Jersey facility, thereby leveraging the company’s U.S.-based manufacturing expertise, Lupin said. The approved product is an oral liquid formulation of apixaban.

Natco Pharma to enhance total investment in eGenesis

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD



Natco is positioning itself in multiplex gene-editing and genome-engineering platform

Natco Pharma is deepening its investment in clinical-stage biotechnology company eGenesis, increasing its planned investment through subsidiaries to \$16.7 million from the earlier announced \$14 million. Under the revised investment plan, Natco Pharma’s Canadian subsidiary will invest \$13.7 million, while Natco Pharma USA LLC will contribute \$3 million. On completion of the transaction, Natco’s total investment in eGenesis will rise to \$24.7 million. Natco, through its Canadian subsidiary, had in 2024 invested \$8 million in

available for patients suffering from organ failure. The company is currently advancing programmes focused on kidney transplantation, acute liver failure and heart transplantation. In March 2024, eGenesis achieved a milestone by announcing the world’s first transplant of a genetically modified pig kidney into a living human patient. The procedure was conducted under the U.S. Food and Drug Administration’s Expanded Access pathway. The company subsequently performed pig kidney transplants in two additional patients, with Natco stating that the outcomes so far have been “exceptionally positive”.

note at 95.89 and hit the intraday low of 96.05 against the American currency. The unit touched the day’s high of 95.87 before ending the session at 95.97 against the greenback, registering a 22 paise fall from its previous close. On Friday, the rupee appreciated 24 paise to close at 95.75 against the U.S.

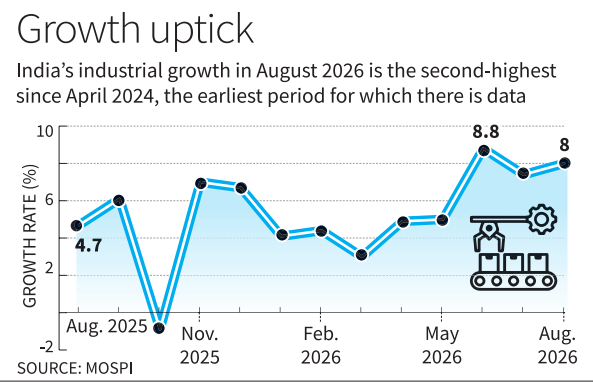
Industrial growth quickens to 8% in Aug.

The growth in August is the second-highest for the period going back to April 2024, for which the new series of the IIP has data

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Industrial growth in India quickened to 8% in August 2026 from 7.35% a month earlier, driven by a strong performance in the manufacturing, electricity, capital goods, and consumer goods sectors. Growth in the Index of Industrial Production, data on which was released by the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation on Monday, was last quicker in June 2026 when it touched 8.8%.

The growth in August is the second-highest for the period going back to April 2024 for which the new series of the IIP has data. “This [August growth] was aided by sharp growth in capital goods, intermediate, infrastructure, and consumer durable goods,” Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at the Bank of Baroda said. “For the five



months period, growth was at 6.7%,” Mr. Sabnavis added. “If this is maintained, India can register growth of 7-8% for the year on the back of higher growth during the festival season with demand building up. This makes the third quarter very critical for industry.” The manufacturing sector grew at 8.95% in August 2026, the second-highest in the history of the new series of the IIP after the 9.5% seen in June 2026. A deeper look showed that the

growth in the sector was driven by motor vehicles, electric and non-electric machinery, electronics, textiles, beverages, rubber, and non-metallic products. The electricity sector saw growth quicken to a 27-month-high of 12.3% in August 2026, which, according to Mr. Sabnavis, was supported by growth in both conventional and renewable electricity. The capital goods sector grew by 16.9%, which was however a three-month low.

Tata Trusts proposes recast of Tata Sons to avoid listing

Lalendu Mishra
MUMBAI



A view of Bombay House, the headquarters of the Tata Group

Tata Trusts, the majority shareholder of Tata Sons Private Limited with a 66% stake, has proposed a restructuring plan aimed at retaining the holding company’s private status and avoiding a potential listing requirement under Reserve Bank of India (RBI) regulations. The plan involves merging two Tata Group entities – Tata Electronics Systems Solutions Private Limited (TESS) and Tata Consulting Engineers (TCE) – with Tata Sons, thereby changing its regulatory classification. Tata Trusts has written to the Tata Sons board seeking approval of the proposal and initiating the process of obtaining the RBI’s no-objection certificate. The proposed reorganisation is aimed at ensuring that Tata Sons ceases to qualify as either a Non-Banking Financial Company (NBFC) or a Core Investment Company (CIC), categories that bring additional regulatory obligations, including compliance with listing norms for certain entities.

According to Tata Trusts, the merged entity would have operating revenues of ₹1.05 lakh crore as of March 31, 2026, significantly higher than income from financial assets at ₹40,072 crore. This would ensure that financial investments do not constitute the dominant source of income, helping Tata Sons move outside the principal business criteria for an NBFC. The Trusts said the amalgamated entity would also not meet the criteria for a CIC. Its net assets would stand at ₹2 lakh crore, with investments in group companies account-

ing for ₹1.77 lakh crore – below the 90% threshold required for CIC classification. The restructuring marks a return to Tata Sons’ earlier operating model, where the holding company also housed businesses and generated operating revenues. Tata Trusts pointed out that for nearly eight decades of its 100-year history, Tata Sons had operated businesses alongside its role as the group’s holding entity. “Tata Consultancy Services was a business division of Tata Sons until 2004 before being demerged into a separate subsidiary,” the Trusts said, adding that several other Tata businesses followed a similar structure in the past. The move comes amid regulatory pressure on Tata Sons after RBI classified it as an upper-layer NBFC and mandated enhanced compliance requirements. The company had been exploring various options, including a possible public listing, to meet regulatory obligations.

F1000 円券 表

Pickups to idle plants: auto firms eye lifeline via defence boom

Prediction markets' push into the U.S. equities raises regulatory alarm bells

The image shows a close-up of a smartphone screen displaying the Polymarket logo, which consists of a square with a diagonal line from the bottom-left to the top-right. The word "Polymarket" is written in white text next to the logo. The background is a solid blue color.

“

Polymarket International

Malaysia's gambit to make durian most wanted

DurianBB founder Adrian Choy's offers durian ice cream, desserts and dried durian at a cafe alongside coffee flavoured with the Musang King variety. His brand also offers guided farm tours.

Italy's Stellantis is planning to sell an idled Canadian factory to armoured-vehicle maker Roshel, while earlier this month Germany's Volkswagen agreed to sell its Osnabrueck plant to Israel's Aurelius Capital and German state of Lower Saxony for a project with Rafael Advanced Defense Systems.

KYAUKTAW

33 killed in military air strike in Myanmar’s Rakhine: rebel group



A military air strike on a market in the town of Kyauktaw in Myanmar’s Rakhine State killed 33 people on Monday and wounded 36 more, according to Arakan Army, the rebel faction which controls the area. Nearly half-a-million people are living displaced in the State due to the civil war unleashed by a 2021 military coup. AFP

FAIRFORD

Iran denies link to alleged bomb plot at U.S.-operated airbase in U.K.



Iran on Monday denied involvement in a suspected bomb plot at U.K.’s Royal Air Force Fairford base used by the U.S., as police said five men arrested nearby were all London-based Britons. Tehran’s denial, issued via its embassy in London, followed widespread U.K. media reports that police were probing possible Iranian links. AFP

JERUSALEM

Netanyahu met UAE President in unannounced trip: Israeli media



Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu had made an unannounced trip to the UAE to meet President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, Israeli media reported on Sunday. The visit follows reports that the Emirati leader warned Mr. Netanyahu ahead of Hamas’s October 7 attack, but the Israeli premier failed to inform security services. AFP

WASHINGTON

Trump offered to sell weapons to China during Xi visit: U.S. envoy



U.S. President Donald Trump offered to sell arms to his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping in response to concern over weapons sales to Taiwan. “President Trump said, ‘Hey, we sell arms to people around the world.’ He actually asked President Xi would he like to buy some?” U.S. Ambassador to China David Perdue told Fox News. AFP

U.S. will be forced out, says Mojtaba as mediators work to broker a deal

Iran’s Supreme Leader says ‘enemy forces suffered painful blows’ in first remarks since Trump rejected Tehran’s proposal; Qatari mediators are expected to hold separate discussions with Iranian Minister Araghchi in New York and the U.S. side

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran’s Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei said on Monday the United States would be forced to leave West Asia after suffering “painful blows”, according to a statement carried by state television. Mr. Khamenei made the remarks despite attempts to revive talks aimed at ending the fighting. “Today, having suffered painful blows at the hands of valiant fighters and the guardians of the Strait of Hormuz, they (the enemies) do not venture beyond the Arabian Sea,” Mr. Khamenei said in the



Tehran transit: Commuters drive past a portrait of Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei at Baharestan Square in Iran’s capital. AFP

written statement attributed to him, without explicitly mentioning the U.S. “Whenever they have braved this risk, they have only brought harm upon themselves. It will not be long before the Arabian

Sea, too, would rid itself of their presence,” he added. Iran and the U.S have been vying for control over Hormuz since the war started with U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran in February. Before the war began, the

strategic shipping route carried about a fifth of the world’s oil and gas. Meanwhile, Qatari mediators are expected to hold separate talks with Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi in New York and with the U.S. side on Monday or Tuesday, an official briefed on the negotiations said. Iran’s semi-official ISNA news agency also confirmed that Mr. Araghchi would meet the mediators.

Seven-day proposal The talks are expected to focus on an amended version of a seven-day proposal that Iran presented last week on the sidelines of the the UN General As-

sembly. Iran’s plan envisages ending all hostilities in Iran and Lebanon, unfreezing of its foreign assets, lifting sanctions on its oil sector, and an end to the U.S. naval blockade. Tehran would then reopen Hormuz, and the two sides would resume talks on Iran’s nuclear programme. U.S. President Donald Trump said on Saturday he had rejected Iran’s proposal, saying Tehran wanted a swift agreement because of the crippling economic pressure it is under. However, he also told Axios on Sunday that he expected U.S. negotiators to engage in further talks this week. (With inputs from Reuters)

Pope urges Europeans to welcome migrants as family

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

Pope Leo XIV called for a more welcoming attitude towards migrants in Europe as he concluded a four-day visit to France. Speaking in Metz, once the home of Robert Schuman, one of the European Union’s founding fathers and a proponent of reconciliation after the Second World War, the Pope criticised calls by leaders to increase arms expenditure, saying it was contrary to the process of peace through dialogue. The head of the Catholic Church was accompanied to Metz by French President Emmanuel Macron. “We see many men and women fleeing war and persecution,” the Pope said, citing the case of the Canary Islands, which has



Pope Leo XIV

seen an influx of migrants from Africa. “We need to welcome people. We need to integrate them as a member of our own family, giving them the possibility to develop their skills and live according to their values,” he added. In an apparent nod to the EU’s official policies, the Pope acknowledged the need to fight human trafficking and to imple-

ment policies that will allow people to live on their own lands. He also said that migrants needed to be taught the history of the lands they are joining, and he called for dialogue between different groups. His remarks come as the far right in Europe is making surges. France’s own nativist party, National Rally, won a record 14 seats in the Senate over the weekend, giving it the right to form a legislative caucus. The Pope also made veiled references to his opposition to abortion and the assisted dying, asking people to “love life at every moment” and to “fight for life”. Speaking on Sunday in Lourdes, the Pope had pushed back against abortion rights and French laws on assisted dying, calling the process “false compassion”.

Russia carries out drone strikes across Ukraine; seven killed

Associated Press
KYIV

Russia’s round-the-clock bombardment of targets in Ukraine killed at least seven people and wounded 80 more, officials said on Monday. Moscow’s forces pounded apartment blocks, data centres and a building of the National Academy of Sciences of Ukraine in Kyiv, among other targets. Russian drone attacks on the Kyiv region killed four people, officials said. A woman was killed in a Russian strike on Kyiv’s Shevchenkivskiy district. The strike hit the National Academy of Sciences of Ukraine, the latest cultural

landmark in the capital to be damaged. One drone struck an office centre in central Dnipro, killing three people, local authorities said. Russia’s Defense Ministry said its forces struck two data centres as well as several gas stations in Kyiv, a distribution hub belonging to the Nova Poshta postal service in Odesa, a cargo ship in the Black Sea and another one in the port of Chornomorsk. ‘Gains in Donetsk’ Meanwhile, Ukraine’s Third Army Corps said on Monday it had recaptured 51 square kilometres from the Russians in the Donetsk region.

Sombre shores



Beachgoers gather around a whale carcass that washed up at City Beach in Perth, Australia, on Monday. AFP

Seoul seeks apology from Ukraine in row over N. Korean POWs

Agence France-Presse
SEOUL

South Korea’s presidential office has demanded an apology from Ukraine for denying an agreement to keep the transfer of two North Korean prisoners of war to Seoul confidential. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy disclosed last week that his country had sent two North Korean soldiers to the South, saying they were “not easy to capture alive”. Hours after Zelenskyy’s remarks at the UN, South Korea’s President Lee Jae Myung expressed his dismay. “I do not know why the Ukrainian side broke

the agreement and made the matter public, but it is very disappointing,” he wrote on X. Seoul said confidentiality was key to protect the POWs’ relatives from repercussions in North Korea. Mr. Zelenskyy’s aide Dmytro Lytvyn sought to play down the disclosure, saying that the President did not share any personal details. But Seoul condemned what it viewed as a breach of trust, noting that Mr. Zelenskyy’s press office had denied there was a confidentiality deal. The dispute risks complicating Kyiv’s efforts to obtain weapons from allies including South Korea to fight off Russian attacks.

Ebola cases top 8,000 as Congo struggles to control outbreak

Agence France-Presse
KINSHASA

The Democratic Republic of Congo has logged more than 8,000 cases of Ebola, including almost 4,000 deaths, amid the worst outbreak in the country’s history, according to data from the Congolese authorities on Monday. In mid-May, the DRC officially declared its 17th Ebola breakout, a deadly disease that has killed more than 15,000 people in Africa over the past 50 years. To date, authorities have recorded 8,067 cases – including 3,901 deaths and 2,070 recoveries – since the start of the current crisis, representing a

Current outbreak has spread to seven provinces; fatality rate at 48.4%, data shows fatality rate of 48.4%, the latest official data showed. Starting in Ituri province, the outbreak has spread to seven provinces, with Ituri, North Kivu and Upper-Uele accounting for the majority of cases. Following a rapid increase, the number of cases has levelled off, according to the African Union’s health agency Africa CDC, which nonetheless sees the outbreak as “not under control”. Several treatments and

vaccines are being trialled against the Bundibugyo strain of the Ebola virus behind the latest case flurry but for which there is currently no approved vaccine or treatment. The health response lacks resources in remote areas, where the presence of armed groups complicates movement, amid mistrust from some sections of the population, which has led to violence targeting humanitarian staff. The first doses of the Ervebo vaccine, which has been proven effective against the hitherto most common Zaire strain of the virus, have been administered in recent weeks to frontline health volunteers as part of a clinical trial.

U.S., China unveil list of ‘non-sensitive’ products under \$30 billion tariff cut

Associated Press
HONG KONG

The U.S. and China on Monday released reciprocal lists of non-sensitive products worth about \$30 billion each that will see tariff cuts, in a deal expected to help bolster bilateral trade. The details came days after Chinese President Xi Jinping met with U.S. President Donald Trump in Washington in his first state visit to the U.S. since 2015. China’s Commerce Ministry said in a statement the agreement will help strengthen trade cooperation. The lists included 1,619 items of U.S. goods enter-



Trade diplomacy: The details come days after Chinese President Xi Jinping met with U.S. President Donald Trump in Washington. AFP

ing China, ranging from agricultural items (excluding soybeans), hair and personal care products to timber and medical equipment. Coal from the U.S. will also be included. For Chinese goods exported to the U.S., 77 cate-

gories were covered, including fireworks, tableware, toys like dolls and puzzles, glass and wooden Christmas ornaments and soccer balls. Tariff rates on over 90% of the products would be subject to “most-favoured-

nation” levels, the Chinese Ministry said, meaning that country-specific tariffs will effectively be eliminated. U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer said the product lists focused on “non-sensitive goods on each side that could benefit from more favourable tariff treatment.” The deal could help secure market access for U.S. farmers, manufacturers, businesses and workers, while benefiting American consumers with imports from China including household goods and toys, Mr. Greer said. Sectors of strategic importance, such as chips, electric vehicles and batteries, were not covered under the agreement.

Hungary lifts immunity of PM, Orban-era Ministers

Agence France-Presse
BUDAPEST

Hungary’s Parliament on Monday lifted the immunity of Prime Minister Peter Magyar and two former Ministers under nationalist ex-leader Viktor Orban, so they could be investigated in separate criminal cases. The probes against the Ministers are the first graft investigations against top government figures from Mr. Orban’s 16 years in power. Mr. Magyar, who is being probed separately for alleged theft, asked for his immunity to be lifted so he could clear himself of “character assassination”.



Captain Ibrahim Traore, 38, now spearheads his ‘progressive and popular’ revolution in Burkina Faso. AP

Burkina’s leader follows steps of anti-colonial hero

Agence France-Presse
ABIDJAN

Captain Ibrahim Traore will on Wednesday have led Burkina Faso for four years, the same as Thomas Sankara, the charismatic hero of African rebellion whose legacy he wants to carry forward - but through harsher measures.

“We’ll keep the torch of Burkina’s renaissance burning,” Mr. Traore likes to say, paying tribute to anti-colonial icon Sankara, who he calls the “nation’s hero” and “compass”.

Both men seized power as red beret-wearing young captains and promoted Pan-Africanism and national, economic and cultural autonomy while silencing dissent.

A Marxist-Leninist firebrand, Sankara seized power aged 33 in an August 1983 coup and embarked on a “democratic and popular revolution” focused on anti-imperialism, self-reliance and national sovereignty.

Nicknamed Africa’s Che Guevara, after the iconic figure in Cuba’s communist revolution, Sankara blasted the West for neo-colonialism and hypocrisy and carried out radical reforms.

Sankara sought to reduce the cost of running the state, open up and connect rural areas, pursued education for all, women’s empowerment and priority for local products

But the “revolution” did not run its full course – Sankara was gunned down in another putsch in October 1987. Nearly four decades on, 38-year-old Traore now spearheads his own “progressive and popular” revolution.

It has seen the nationalisation of gold mines and a strategy to revitalise Burkina’s industrial output, from cotton to tomatoes and textiles.

He has also launched a major public infrastructure and urban development initiative called Faso Mebo (Build the Country), which relies on enlisting citizens to build roads using local materials.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Sambavi Parthasarathy

Israel’s Central Elections Committee (CEC), on Wednesday, voted to bar the country’s main Arab parties from contesting the October 27 elections to the country’s parliament, the Knesset. There have been a series of attempts for decades to disqualify Arab parties from contesting elections, and the latest move comes at a time when these parties have a chance to play a crucial role in the upcoming government.

Recent polls by media outlets have suggested that neither Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu’s coalition nor the Zionist opposition bloc will be able to secure 61 seats required for parliamentary majority in the 120-member Knesset and projected that the Arab parties could win up to 12 seats. The CEC’s move to disqualify the Ra’am party and the Joint List (an alliance of Arab parties Balad, Hadash and Ta’al) comes at this juncture. The panel has also voted to disqualify Joint List individual candidate Ofer Cassif and Balad leader Sami Abu Shehadeh.

Reason for the ban

However, the panel’s decision is not final. It requires the approval of the Supreme Court of Justice for disqualifying individual candidates, and the disqualified political party

has the right to appeal to the Supreme Court.

The CEC, responding to petitions filed by Likud and Jewish Power parties as well as the Choose Life Forum, a non-government organisation, voted 18-5 with one abstention to disqualify the Ra’am party led by M.K. Mansour Abbas on grounds of supporting the armed struggle of a terrorist organisation/enemy state, inciting racism and rejecting Israel’s existence. However, as per Adalah, the legal centre for Arab rights in Israel, no supporting evidence was presented.

The move to bar the Joint List relied on bills and actions from previous Knessets, some of which have already been examined and dismissed by the Supreme Court. Mr. Cassif’s dismissal rested on his criticism of the army and the government for committing war crimes against Palestinians. Mr. Shehadeh’s disqualification rested on the claim that he expressed support for armed struggle.

Adalah, which represented the now-banned political parties and individual candidates before the CEC, on its site, referred to the hearings and the motions as “an arbitrary, inciting and racist process” aimed at “persecuting ideas the majority does not accept” which ended with the disqualification of all Palestinian representations in the Israeli Knesset. The organisation is also representing them before the

Scandal-weary Brazilians to vote as 80-year-old Lula faces Bolsonaro son

Agence France-Presse
BRASILIA

Jaded by a dizzying array of scandals, Brazilians vote on Sunday in a nail-biter election pitting leftist President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva against right-wing senator Flavio Bolsonaro.

The election will determine if Latin America’s biggest economy joins a rightward shift in the region that has been cheered on by U.S. President Donald Trump.

In a deeply polarised nation, Brazilians are feeling a weary sense of deja vu in an election offering a familiar political script: Mr. Lula, 80, seeking a fourth



Opinion polls show Lula Da Silva (L) slightly ahead of Flavio Bolsonaro (R) in the first round vote. REUTERS

term, is facing off against the son of far-right former president Jair Bolsonaro.

Many of the country’s 160 million registered voters have yet to make up their minds after a cam-

paign dominated by scandals that have shaken both sides.

“I’m still undecided. Because corruption is so blatant. It’s difficult,” said Joel da Silva, 42, a doorman in

Rio de Janeiro.

Meanwhile, opinion polls show Mr. Lula slightly ahead of Mr. Flavio Bolsonaro in the first round vote.

The two leaders are in a dead heat in an expected runoff on October 25.

Mr. Lula, a global leftist icon, made a dramatic return to office in 2023, following a stint in jail on corruption convictions that were later annulled on a jurisdictional technicality.

Mr. Flavio Bolsonaro was thrust into the electoral race after his father was jailed for attempting a coup against Mr. Lula when he lost a 2022 election bid.

Mexico’s journalists have long faced bullets; now lawsuits against them are rising

Associated Press
CAMPECHE

Politicians and judges are increasingly attempting to shut down press freedoms in Mexico, raising concerns among journalism watchdog groups.

In 2025, a new lawsuit against journalists or media outlets was filed every six days in Mexico, 69 cases in total, triple the previous year, according to Article 19, a press freedom watchdog.

Politicians have discovered that lawsuits are “a much more effective way to silence the press because they give the impression of legality,” said Jan-Albert Hootsen, the Mexico representative for the Committee to Protect Journalists.

Tribuna, a 50-year-old daily newspaper in the southeastern state of Campeche, became the flagship media outlet during the administrations of the Institutional Revolutionary Party which governed the state for nearly a century.

Then Layda Sansores, of the ruling Morena party, won the 2021 gubernatorial election. And things quickly changed.

She pulled government advertising from Tribuna – advertising that was necessary for the paper to continue to publish. She started her own television program promoting her administration and demeaning journalists, handing out Oscar-style awards – called the “Golden Pinocchio” – to journalists she deemed the biggest “liars.”

Tribuna ran columns railing against her, and those columns sometimes went beyond her politics. Criticism intensified with gender-specific and homophobic attacks. Then in 2024, Tribuna, starved of revenue, ceased to print though it continued to publish online, including scathing articles against Ms. Sansores.

Bar from journalism

Ms. Sansores responded with several civil and criminal complaints against Jorge Luis González, who served as its editor for three decades and continues as a contributor, alleging moral damage, gender-based political violence and hate speech.

In mid-2025, one of Ms. Sansores’ criminal cases



Jorge Luis González (L), former editor of Tribuna, and journalist Lorenzo Chim Caamal host a programme in Campeche. AP

against Mr. González led judges to bar him from journalism for two years and to have a judicial censor review Tribuna articles before online publication. Press freedom watchdogs strongly denounced the decision, arguing that prior censorship is unacceptable and concerned the decision might set a precedent.

Milestone launch



Fired up: SpaceX Starship Flight 14 launches from its launch pad at Boca Chica Beach, Texas on Monday. The megarocket reached orbit for the first time, in a major milestone for SpaceX’s plans, including trips to the Moon and Mars. AP

persecuting or censoring the press and says her lawsuits are to protect women. She did not respond to requests for comment.

Several local reporters say she also changed the way authorities try to control the press. Campeche officials now “stop you with lawsuits,” said Ronny Aguilar, a local journalist and digital content creator.

Reporters Without Borders has denounced the growing and widespread use of laws as weapons against the press, especially in the Americas.

U.S. President Donald Trump has banned three news outlets’ reporters from the White House, escalating his efforts – in the courts and through administrative action. The Associated Press also is suing

following the President’s decision last year to bar AP reporters from the Oval Office, Air Force One and some events in retaliation for the news outlet’s decision not to follow his lead in changing the name of the Gulf of Mexico, which lies partially in Mexican and other waters.

7 journalists killed

In Mexico, the weaponisation of the judicial system comes amid an increase in journalist killings. Seven journalists were killed this year, five of them in less than three months, one of the deadliest spikes in over a decade, according to CPJ.

Some of those targeted with lawsuits, including Veracruz crime reporter Rafael León, acknowledge that the experience has

changed how they work. Although terrorism charges against Mr. León were dropped after President Claudia Sheinbaum intervened, he now reports less and works in fear, he said.

Ms. Sheinbaum has softened the hostile tone her predecessor, Andrés Manuel López Obrador, used toward some journalists, but a new federal regulation to protect “audiences’ rights” set to take effect this month has alarmed press watchdogs.

The President insists it will better protect the public’s right to complain about any publication without leading to censorship. Some groups fear it could allow the state to intervene in some disputes ahead of Mexico’s 2027 elections.

INBRIEF



Spain takes home Women's u-20 football World Cup title

Spain added to its burgeoning haul of global football titles after winning the Women's under-20 football World Cup at Lodz (Poland) on Sunday. Goalkeeper Laia Lopez saved two penalties in a 4-3 shootout win over defending champion North Korea in the final. FIFA President Gianni Infantino watched s Lopez saved spot kicks from Choe Yon-a and Pak Il-Sim in the shootout after the game had ended 0-0. Colombia beat Italy 4-3 on penalties to win the bronze medal match.



USA clinches 11th consecutive Presidents Cup crown

The United States made a stunning rally to capture an 11th consecutive Presidents Cup golf title at Medinah on Sunday, completing a 17-13 victory over the Internationals with US President Donald Trump in attendance. Jacob Bridgeman secured the clinching point by sinking a four-foot par putt at the 18th hole to defeat Australian Min Woo Lee 1-up. The Americans improved to 14-1-1 in the biennial rivalry after trailing 10.5-7.5 entering 12 concluding singles matches.



Baird quits as CA chair, Boon named interim chief

Cricket Australia (CA) chair Mike Baird announced he was standing down amid a backlash over the partial privatisation of the Big Bash League. He will leave the role after CA's annual meeting in late October. CA has named former Test opener David Boon, in pic., as interim replacement.

LIVE TELECAST

India-A vs Australia-A: Second 'Test', day 1, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.
Cricket: Asian Games (Men): Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10.30 a.m.
Football: Nations League, Sony Sports Ten 2, 5 & LIV, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Wednesday)
Asian Games: Sony Sports Ten 2, 3, 5 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Wednesday)

Greece stuns Germany in a losing home debut for Klopp

NATIONS LEAGUE

Reuters
AUSBURG

Greece scored a 74th-minute goal through Dimitris Kourbelis to stun host Germany 1-0 in their Nations League Group A on Sunday to top the group and spoil coach Juergen Klopp's home debut on the German bench.

It was the first ever victory for the Greeks in 11 matches against the Germans, and they now lead their group on six points from two matches. Germany is on one point. Klopp has now failed to win either of his two matches in charge following a 1-1 draw against the Dutch in Amsterdam on Thursday.

In the same group,



On target: Kourbelis, centre, takes off after his winning strike for Greece. AP

Netherlands earned a 2-1 victory over Serbia thanks to Mexx Meerdink's double strike on his second appearance for his country. It was the first win under new coach Xavi Hernandez.

The results: League A: Serbia 1 (Jovic 46) lost to Netherlands 2 (Meerdink 30-pen, 69); Germany 0 lost to Greece 1 (Kourbelis 74);

Denmark 2 (Davies 53-og, Isaksen 66) bt Wales 0; Norway 1 (Haaland 51) lost to Portugal 2 (Felix 17, Ramos 54).
League B: Austria 3 (Affengruber 23, Adamu 45+2, Chukwuemeka 61) bt Kosovo 1 (Zhegrova 83-pen); Israel 0 lost to Rep. of Ireland 3 (Parrott 13, Idah 16, Moylan 25).
League D: Gibraltar 0 drew with Andorra 0; Lithuania 1 (A. Kucys 9-pen) drew with Azerbaijan 1 (Emreli 14).

Unadkat sizzles again; Warwickshire triumphs

Sports Bureau

Left-arm pacer Jaydev Unadkat earned seven wickets, including a five-wicket haul in the first innings, as Sussex ended its English county championship first-division campaign with a 197-run victory over Hampshire in Southampton. Manav Suthar's Warwickshire clinched the title after defeating Leicestershire by an innings and 79 runs in Birmingham.

Indians in county action: I div.: Jaydev Unadkat (Sussex): 5/32, 2/29 & 1 n.o., 17 n.o. Sussex beat Hampshire by 197 runs.
Mahipal Lomror (Surrey): 10, 16 n.o. & 4/212. Match drawn against Somerset.
Rahul Chahar (Surrey): 3. Match drawn versus Somerset.
Manav Suthar (Warwickshire): 0/6, 1/26 & 19. Warwickshire defeated Leicestershire by an



Prasidh. NIRMAL HARINDRAN

knowing what exactly must be done, there is clarity within the team, there is clarity in me as to what I do when I come in. There is enough communication going on. All this helps me bowl well."

Competition

About the competition in pace-bowling slots in the Indian team, he said: "It is great. We are seeing a lot of fast bowlers coming in. It is really good for the Indian cricket team, honestly. You keep pushing each other.

"And every time we go into nets, we know the kind of bowlers that we're bowling amongst. I would say Indian cricket, in terms of fast bowling, is in good hands".

Indian cricket, in terms of fast bowling, is in good hands: Prasidh

WI IN INDIA

P.K. Ajith Kumar
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Prasidh Krishna, like all aspiring cricketers of his generation, grew up watching Virat Kohli bat.

On Sunday night at the Greenfield Stadium here, the Indian quick got to watch from the dressing room the master conjuring up an extraordinary knock.

"It was unbelievable," he said, echoing just about everyone who witnessed that stunning assault by Kohli in the first ODI, which India won with more than eight overs remaining.

"Sitting outside, we were thinking, what do we bowl to him at that moment? He was striking the ball really, really well. We were all excited."

Prasidh too contributed to the Indian win, claiming two wickets. And he has been having a good time with the white ball; he is India's leading bowler in ODIs this year with 15 wickets from eight matches.

"Every single session we go in, we are looking to improve at something," he said. "And every game poses a different kind of challenge. When you come in

Gujarat Giants keeps 15 from its present squad, the most among the five franchises, ahead of the fifth season; auction to be held in Kochi on Oct. 28



Foreign flavour: Bell, centre, and Voll, left, are two of the four overseas players that defending champion RCB has retained. FILE PHOTO: EMMANUAL YOGINI

WPL

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

A total of 63 cricketers, including 23 overseas players, have been retained by the five Women's Premier League (WPL) franchises ahead of next month's auction. The deadline for the franchises to announce their retentions for the fifth season ended on Monday.

Gujarat Giants retained 15 players, the most among the five teams. Unsurprisingly, UP Warriorz, given its wretched record in the tournament, retained the fewest at 11.

Defending champion Royal Challengers Bengaluru has kept hold of 13 players. It includes four overseas retentions – Lauren Bell, Nadine de Klerk, Georgia Voll and Ellyse Perry. Among the players released by RCB is all-round

der Grace Harris.

Delhi Capitals, which has finished runner-up across all four seasons, has also retained 13 members.

The five overseas players that will continue to feature for DC are Annabel Sutherland, Chinelle Henry, Laura Wolvaardt, Lucy Hamilton and Marizanne Kapp. Former South Africa wicketkeeper-batter Lizelle Lee, who smashed 320 runs in 10 innings in 2026, has been released.

Mumbai Indians, meanwhile, has retained 11 players. The WPL auction will be held in Kochi on October 28.

Retained players: Delhi

Capitals: Annabel Sutherland*, Chinelle Henry*, Deeya Yadav, Jemimah Rodriguez, Laura Wolvaardt*, Lucy Hamilton*, Mamatha Madiwala, Marizanne Kapp*, Minnu Mani, N Sree Charani, Nandini Sharma, Niki Prasad, Shafali Verma

Gujarat Giants: Anushka Sharma, Ashleigh Gardner*, Beth Mooney*, Bharti Fulmali, Georgia

Wareham*, Happy Kumari, Jintimani Kalita, Kanika Ahuja, Kashvee Gautam, Kim Garth*, Rajeshwari Gayakwad, Renuka Singh, Sophie Devine*, Tanuja Kanwer, Yastika Bhatia.

Mumbai Indians: Amanjot Kaur, Amelia Kerr*, Harmanpreet Kaur, Hayley Matthews*, Nat Sciver-Brunt*, Nicola Carey*, Rahila Firdous, Sajeevan Sajana, Sanskriti Gupta, Shabnim Ismail*, Vaishnavi Sharma

Royal Challengers Bengaluru: Arundhati Reddy, Ellyse Perry*, Georgia Voll*, Lauren Bell*, Nadine De Klerk*, Pooja Vastrakar, Prathyoshsha Kumar, Prema Rawat, Radha Yadav, Richa Ghosh, Sayali Satghare, Shreyanka Patil, Smriti Mandhana

UP Warriorz: Deepti Sharma, Harleen Deol, Kranti Gaud, Meg Lanning*, Phoebe Litchfield*, Pratika Rawal, Shikha Pandey, Shipra Giri, Simran Shaikh, Sophie Ecclestone*, Tara Norris* *Overseas players.

Salary cap available: DC: ₹1.1 crore; **GG:** ₹1.25 crore; **MI:** ₹1 crore; **RCB:** ₹1.15 crore; **UPW:** ₹3.65 crore.

Available slots: DC: 5 (1 overseas); **GG:** 3 (1); **MI:** 7 (1); **RCB:** 5 (2); **UPW:** 7 (2).

Lakshya's unbeaten double ton puts India under-19 in the driver's seat

YOUTH TEST

Shayan Acharya
RAJKOT

Lakshya Raichandani carried his rich white-ball form into red-ball cricket, scoring an unbeaten 210 (256b, 20x4, 4x6) as India under-19 reached 430 for eight to take a 213-run lead over Australia under-19 on the second day of the first Youth Test.

Lakshya stitched together a 124-run partnership with captain Yashbardhan Singh Chauhan (54, 81b, 7x4) for the third wicket to help India recover from 46 for two, with Sagar Virk and Kushagra Ojha falling early.

As the Niranjan Shah Stadium surface eased out on Monday, the two settled in. Yashbardhan was positive, playing in the V and rotating the strike, while Lakshya took his time before opening up.

With the temperature soaring and the Australian bowlers tiring, it seemed both batters would reach their centuries. But Yashbardhan was caught behind off Kasey Barton, ending the partnership.

The Australian spinners – left-armer Connor Gregory and leg-spinner Spencer Green – then tightened the screws, taking two wickets apiece as India lost wickets in clusters.

Lakshya held firm, adding 51 with Ayaan Akram,

who replaced Pranav Ravagavendra, before putting on an unbroken 137-run stand for the ninth wicket with local boy Mohit Ulva (58 n.o., 56b, 5x4, 4x6).

Lakshya played each ball on its merit, while Mohit upped the tempo, finding the boundary regularly. The Australian spinners briefly shifted the momentum, but with Lakshya holding the fort, India remained firmly in control.

By stumps, Lakshya had batted through the day and remained unbeaten to put India in command.

The scores: Australia u-19 217 vs. India u-19 430/8 in 92 overs (Lakshya Raichandani 210 batting, Yashbardhan Singh 54, Mohit Ulva 58 batting, Kasey Barton 3/64).



Lakshya. SAURASHTRA CRICKET ASSOCIATION

Batters seek quick fixes to ace spin trial

AUS-A IN INDIA

Abhishek Saini
PUDUCHERRY

Batters on either side will hope to find their feet and hold sway in the slow conditions of the Siechem Cricket Stadium here, as the second 'Test' between India-A and Australia-A begins on Tuesday.

Three of the four in-

nings in the opening game concluded inside 60 overs, with the first essay being the only exception courtesy of ton-up Kumar Kushagra. Devdutt Padikkal and B. Sai Sudharsan got their eye in, but only by piling up lengthier essays will they fully utilise this 'A' fixture, which is primarily aimed at attuning them for next year's Border-Gavaskar Trophy.

The Australia-A batting

line-up boasted of four capped batters, yet none could deliver a fifty across the two innings. Four of the Australia-A top-five – Nathan McSweeney, Peter Handscomb, Jason Sangha, Campbell Kellaway – average over 50 against spin, but none could tame Shams Mulani and Tanush Kotian when the ball stayed low.

Todd Murphy and Corey Rocchiccioli were no less

than their counterparts. The former got match figures of seven for 135 in the first game, and he'll cherish more wickets as keepsakes before he returns to these conditions in January.

Spinners shared a majority of the spoils, but pacers, who returned with 17 of the 40 wickets, too conjured up unplayable deliveries on a surface offering uneven bounce.

Racing Ruler pulls off a surprise in the feature event

HYDERABAD: The 15-to-1 long-shot Racing Ruler, ridden by Kuldeep Singh Sr., shocked hot favourite Love All in the Dr. Harish Chandra Memorial Trophy, the main event of Monday's races.

The winner is owned by M/s. Bollineni Krishnaiah, Seshadri Reddy Pochana, Ashok Ranpise, K.S.V. Prasad Raju, Mukund Kakani, Teegala Vijender Reddy, Teegala Sumant Reddy, Harinath Reddy Teegala & Mrs. Smita Bajoria. K.S.V. Prasad Raju trains the winner. Prasad Raju saddled two more winners of the day.

1. NALGONDA PLATE (DIV. I) (1,200M): LION'S PRIDE (R.N. Darshan) 1, Mantle Plume (B.R. Kumar) 2, Menlo Park (Shivam) 3 and Night Whisper (Kuldeep Sr.) 4. 1-1/4, 1-1/2 and Neck. 1m, 14.50s. ₹17 (w), 12, 13 and 92 (p). SHP: 21, THP: 103, FP: 41, Q: 26, Tanala: 522. Favourite: Lion's Pride. Owner: Mr. Yadugiri Kiran Kumar. Trainer: Raza Shehzad.

2. TWIN CITIES PLATE (1,800M): EVANSVILLE (Akshay Kumar) 1, Aakarshaka (Md. Ismail) 2, Silver Arrow (Kuldeep Sr.) 3 and Hoping High (Mohit) 4. 4-1/2, 8-1/2 and 1-1/2. 1m, 54.68s. ₹11 (w), 13, 15 and 21 (p). SHP: 19, THP: 48, FP: 22, Q: 19, Tanala: 120. Favourite: Evansville. Owner: Mr. Rama Krishna Reddy. Trainer: K.S.V. Prasad Raju.

3. NALGONDA PLATE (DIV. II) (1,200M): N R I ROYAL POWER (Afroz Khan) 1, Goddess Of Light

(Akshay K) 2, Sara (Mohit) 3 and My Day (Gaurav) 4. 2-3/4, 1/2 and 1. 1m, 14.36s. ₹122 (w), 23, 15 and 16 (p). SHP: 20, THP: 36, FP: 589, Q: 245, Tanala: 2,058. Favourite: Goddess Of Light. Owner: Mr. Ravinder Reddy Male. Trainer: Dr. Netto.

4. DR. HARISH CHANDRA MEMORIAL TROPHY (1,600M): RACING RULER (Kuldeep Singh Sr.) 1, Love All (Akshay K) 2, Authoritarian (M.S. Deora) 3 and Special Star (P. Sai K) 4. Neck, 3 and 3/4. 1m, 39.3s. ₹54 (w) 29 and 11 (p). SHP: 45, THP: 24, FP: 182, Q: 19, Tanala: 631. Favourite: Love All. Owners: M/s. Bollineni Krishnaiah, Seshadri Reddy Pochana, Ashok Ranpise, K.S.V. Prasad Raju, Mukund Kakani, Teegala Vijender Reddy, Teegala Sumant Reddy, Harinath Reddy Teegala & Mrs. Smita Bajoria. Trainer: K.S.V. Prasad Raju.

5. MAJOR MIR MUJTABA HUSSAIN MEMORIAL TROPHY (DIV. I) (1,200M): TORCHBEARER (Kuldeep Singh Jr.) 1, Clefairy (Akshay K) 2, Shoolin (D.S. Deora) 3 and Romantic Grey (Ashad Asab) 4. Not run: Federer. 1/2, 1/2 and 1. 1m, 14.25s. ₹120 (w), 31, 10 and 34 (p). SHP: 37, THP: 79, FP: 777, Q: 419, Tanala: 8,772. Favourite: Clefairy. Owner: Col. S.B. Nair. Trainer: L.V.R. Deshmukh.

6. NORLE QUEST PLATE (1,200M): REIGNING BEAUTY (Md. Ismail) 1, Knight Regent (Afroz K) 2, N R I

High Power (Akshay K) 3 and Walking Thunder (Kuldeep Sr.) 4. Not run: D Minchu. Head, 2 and Neck. 1m, 14.03s. ₹130 (w), 29, 17 and 11 (p). SHP: 24, THP: 85, FP: 1,408, Q: 587, Tanala: 1,890. Favourite: N R I High Power. Owner: Estate of Late Mr. L. D' Silva. Trainer: Neelesh Rawal.

7. NAGARKURNOOL PLATE (1,400M): LA QUINTA (Akshay Kumar) 1, Konaseema (Md. Ekram) 2, Farsiris (Sohan) 3 and Dream To Fly (G. Naresih) 4. 2-3/4, Neck and 2. 1m, 27.02s. ₹27 (w), 18, 10 and 14 (p). SHP: 38, THP: 69, FP: 77, Q: 30, Tanala: 428. Favourite: La Quinta. Owners: Mr. M. Ramakrishna Reddy, Mr. Bharat Venkat Epur & Mrs. Rajini Meka. Trainer: K.S.V. Prasad Raju.

8. MAJOR MIR MUJTABA HUSSAIN MEMORIAL TROPHY (DIV. II) (1,200M): DYANOOSH (Sonu Kumar) 1, Warwick (Ashad Asbar) 2, Lucky Zone (Kuldeep Jr.) 3 and Mix The Magic (D.S. Deora) 4. 3-1/2, Neck and 1. 1m, 13.56s. ₹112 (w), 54, 25 and 31 (p). SHP: 47, THP: 62, FP: 1,704, Q: 529, Tanala: 13, 047. Favourite: Arthisha. Owners: M/s. Sardar Jivtesh Singh, Md. Sultan & M. Praveen Kumar. Trainer: M.F. Ali Khan.

Jackpot: 70%: ₹5, 89,025 (c/o) & 30%: 28,048 (9 tkts.). Mini Jackpot: (i) 29, 804 (2 tkts.), (ii) 84, 228 (2 tkts.), Treble: (i) 463 (4 tkts.), (ii) 20,295 (1 tk), (iii) 10,409 (6 tkts.).

R. Kaushik

Fast bowling is a very physically demanding and unnatural activity that places immense strain on various different parts of the body. The most affected, one might say, are the back, the knees and the ankles, but the shoulder bears a heavy burden too, as does the heel and the shin.

Fast bowling calls for sheer bloody-mindedness, especially in a country like India where, until perhaps a decade back, the pitches offered absolutely no assistance even in domestic cricket. The diktat to leave a few millimetres of grass, interestingly during Sourav Ganguly’s tenure as the BCCI president, has had a domino effect with the medium-pacers and those slightly quicker than that having a field day at the expense of spin. But even so, it requires a certain mindset to want to embrace fast bowling in the subcontinent - perhaps with the exception of Pakistan, who somehow seem to throw up quicks a dime a dozen.

It’s not as if spin bowling is an easier endeavour. It would seem to be an unequal contest, fast bowlers thundering in from 20 yards to hurl the cherry and the spinners trundling in from five or six yards - unless you were Derek Underwood or Ajantha Mendis - to let go of the ball. But anyone who thinks bowling spin comes easy clearly doesn’t understand cricket enough.

And it’s not as if spinners aren’t putting themselves at the risk of picking up injuries, either. The seam cutting against the inside of the forefinger and the middle finger triggers such pain and discomfort that oftentimes, it’s hard to even grip the ball and well nigh impossible to release it with the desired revs. But such is their devotion to their craft that the finger spinners make light of such terrible exigencies, determined to hoodwink batters in the air and off the surface while being mindful of how much the odds are stacked against them in modern-day cricket.

If the lot of quality finger-spinners is anything but straightforward, think of the wrist-spinner. There is arguably no other type of bowling that asks such probing questions as that of a wristie. For starters, they need to be encouraged to keep at it because a bad delivery is never far away, because such is the very nature of that craft. Especially in one’s formative years, it is very easy to get disheartened, and more so if encouragement isn’t forthcoming from coaches, captains, parents and peers. But even when one establishes themselves at the highest level, the gremlins of self-doubt never disappear completely.

Shane Warne might have made leg-spin look glamorous and ridiculously easy with his larger-than-life persona and a supreme command over how the ball left his hand but hey, how many wrist-spinners have taken 700 Test wickets? Or even 700 wickets in first-class cricket? Warne was the striking exception, the genius touched by greatness long before he made an eminently forgettable Test debut in Sydney in January 1992 against India. Figures of one for 150 - his lone success was double-centurion Ravi Shastri - were hardly flattering, but Warne wasn’t the only to show that it isn’t how you start, but how you develop and finish, that matters the most.

Generous with inputs

Warne wasn’t just a great bowler, he was also generous with his inputs and advice, with his learnings and wisdom. In international cricket, they talk of a fast bowlers’ club, and a spinners’ club. For a long time, the latter was populated by three of the most successful tweekers of all time - Warne, Sri Lankan giant Muttiah Muralitharan (Test cricket’s highest wicket-taker with 800 scalps) and our own Anil Kumble, with the temperament of a fast bowler and the heart of a champion that often took the sheen away from his not inconsiderable skillset.

It was probably little less than providential that two of these three members contributed to a rookie left-arm wrist-spinner - the term Chinaman is frowned upon these days, apparently because it is politically incorrect - announcing himself on the world stage more than nine and a half years back. Kumble was India’s head coach for only one year - more the Indian team’s loss than the towering Bengalee’s - but that was time enough for him to bequeath to Indian cricket that great rarity in the history of the game, a left-arm wrist-spinner.

Through the first three of Australia’s four Tests in India in early 2017, Kuldeep Yadav was steadfastly ignored by Virat Kohli. An unfortunate shoulder injury to the captain forced him to miss the decider in Dharamsala - the series was tied 1-1 - and Ajinkya Rahane, the stand-in skipper, heeded his coach’s words and opted to throw the 22-year-old from Kanpur into the deep end.

Master’s advice

His first bowl is what we tend to call a ‘dream debut’. On a decidedly pacer-friendly day-one strip at the HPCA Stadium, he made Australia’s batters dance to his tune. Kumble had facilitated a conversation



A bank that India can deep dive into in the Africas

Perhaps now, the turnaround is imminent. Only time will tell, but watching Kuldeep run rings around the West Indian batters in Thiruvananthapuram on Sunday in the first ODI, you couldn’t help but wonder why successive team managements haven’t invested more in this now mature, seasoned 31-year-old.

between Warne and Kuldeep before the match, and while English may not have been the latter’s strongest suit at the time, he showed that language is hardly a barrier when it comes to cricket by putting the master’s advice to great effect.

His first Test wicket was that of David Warner, with a flipper that Warne had talked about in detail. Then followed the sticks of Peter Handscomb, Glenn Maxwell - coming off a century in the previous game in Ranchi - and Nagpur as Kuldeep finished with four for 68 from 23 outstanding overs. A start had emerged, you told yourself, a star for whom the sky was the limit.

Kuldeep’s career has, as has been well chronicled, not taken off along expected lines. Nine and a half years after that stirring debut,

he has only 19 Test caps. Somehow, he has been the most expendable of the spinners, ostensibly at the altar of batting depth. For a type of bowler who relies on confidence, trust, encouragement and backing, to be forced to look over his shoulder and wonder if he will get a second Test on the trot isn’t the ideal base from which to perform, as former India leg-spinner Narendra Hirwani agreed during a conversation with this writer a couple of weeks.

Pigeonholed more as a limited-overs bowler - 122 ODIs and 54 T20Is for 198 and 95 scalps respectively - Kuldeep has plugged away manfully in the two shorter formats. He must be hurting immensely at not playing more Tests, even on home patch, and sometimes, that feeling of hurt and maybe not being wanted has manifested itself in scratchy, underwhelming performances that infuriate because one knows that Kuldeep is capable of much, much more.

Turning a corner?

Perhaps now, the turnaround is imminent. Or perhaps, even now, that could be a false dawn. Only time will tell, but watching Kuldeep run rings around the West Indian batters in Thiruvananthapuram on Sunday in the first ODI, you couldn’t help but wonder why successive team managements haven’t invested more in this now mature, seasoned 31-year-old.

Put in on an excellent batting the Caribbeans strip, seemed on course for a total in excess of 350 on the back of sterling opening stand of 135 between Justin Greaves and John Campbell in just 19.2 overs. Enter Kuldeep, so send them tumbling to 198 for five, including wickets in successive deliveries of Greaves and Jewel Andrew, who had no answer to a ripping wrong ‘un that caught the splice of his bat and lobbed to Rohit Sharma at slip.

Kuldeep finished with four for 40, his best ODI figures since September 2023, when he took five for 25 against Pakistan in the Asia Cup in Colombo. Only thrice subsequently in the next 34 ODIs until Sunday did he manage a four-wicket haul, but there was something different about how the ball left his left hand in Thiruvananthapuram.

Flow and confidence

The pace was optimal, the control impeccable, the rhythm very, very evident. It certainly helped that he got a wicket early on because more than anyone else, Kuldeep

thrives on flow and confidence, and once he realised that he was hitting the areas that he was targeting, he appeared so dangerous as to threaten a wicket almost every delivery.

Kohli produced another one of his trademark centuries in a chase, seeing the team home by eight wickets with plenty to spare, and Shubman Gill dazzled with a pleasing hundred of his own, but there truly was only one candidate for the Player of the Match award.

Kuldeep had single-handedly downscaled the West Indian total by at least 50 runs and while there is no gainsaying what the outcome would have been even if Shai Hope’s men had touched or crossed 350, the wrist-spinner pulled the chase down to little more than ordinary proportions with his mesmeric presence at the bowling crease.

Not the best of times

Across formats, Kuldeep hasn’t had the best of times of late. He hasn’t taken more than two wickets in a T20I innings for 12 months, while the last of his five five-fors in Test cricket came in October last year, also against West Indies. His last five bowls in the five-day game have brought him just four successes in 54.5 overs and he had a forgettable Galle Test last month, finishing with match figures of one for 103 from 25 overs as he was comprehensively shaded by finger-spinners Manav Suthar and Ravindra Jadeja.

Kuldeep has found himself at a crossroads so often in his nearly decade-long international career that he must experience a sense of déjà vu whenever he is pushed to a corner. He has found a way to spring back several times, and one can only hope that Sunday is a seminal moment in that it will lead to a sustained expression of tricks and sleight of hand.

Over the next week, in the next two ODIs, and in the five T20Is to follow, he will get further opportunities to build on this grand start to the home season. If he can snare a bagful of wickets, it will put him in an excellent state of mind as India head to New Zealand in three weeks’ time for their first full tour there since January 2020.

Kuldeep is the kind of bowler who can make a decisive impact even on pitches that don’t offer him much help, a bank India will hope to dip into at the 50-over World Cup in the Africas in 12 months’ time.

For long, Kuldeep himself has been his worst enemy; that’s something he and the think-tank must work assiduously to arrest as Indian cricket enters an exciting phase pregnant with glorious possibilities.

NIRMAL HARINDRAN

THE GIST

Kuldeep’s career has, as has been well chronicled, not taken off along expected lines. omehow, he has been the most expendable of the spinners, ostensibly at the altar of batting depth

Kohli produced another one of his trademark centuries in a chase, seeing the team home by eight wickets with plenty to spare, and Gill dazzled with a pleasing hundred of his own, but there truly was only one candidate for the Player of the Match award

Kuldeep had single-handedly downscaled the West Indian total by at least 50 runs

The left-arm wrist spinner has found a way to spring back several times, and one can only hope that Sunday is a seminal moment in that it will lead to a sustained expression of tricks and sleight of hand

